

CITY: Pg 5

Winter pollution gets a rulebook



NATION: Pg 7

Digital India has given India new identity: PM



FILM: Pg 12

'Just for the dance or the song'



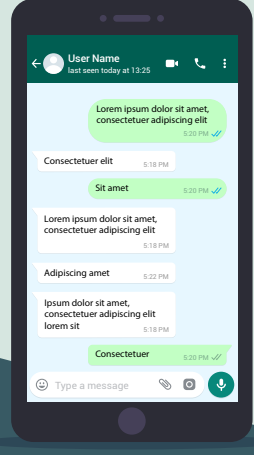
NOTICE CITES CONCERNS OVER FRAUD, PHISHING AND DIGITAL ARREST SCAMS

Centre orders Meta to pause WhatsApp username rollout, seeks reply in 3 days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Wednesday directed Meta not to roll out WhatsApp's proposed username feature in India until government consultations on its privacy, security and legal implications are completed, citing concerns that the new system could lead to more online fraud, impersonation and phishing attacks. The government issued a formal notice to the company's Chief Compliance Officer, asking Meta to submit a detailed explanation, supported by relevant documents, within three days. Officials are examining whether the feature includes sufficient safeguards for Indian users and whether it could make it more difficult for law enforcement agencies to identify offenders involved in cybercrime.

The notice marks the government's first formal intervention in WhatsApp's planned username-based messaging system, which is designed to let users communicate without sharing their mobile phone numbers. According to the notice, authorities believe the feature could "materially increase" incidents of online fraud, phishing, digital arrest scams and impersonation by making it easier for bad actors to contact potential victims. The government also raised concerns that usernames closely resembling those of genuine individuals, public authorities, financial institutions or government agencies could be used to deceive users. The Centre has asked



KEY POINTS

- » Authorities fear usernames could enable impersonation and identity spoofing
- » Meta asked why action should not follow under the IT Act
- » Government cites intermediary obligations under IT Act and 2021 Rules
- » WhatsApp says high-profile usernames are reserved against impersonation
- » Platform promises limits on unsolicited messaging and username guessing

FIRST-TIME MESSAGES WILL SHOW ACCOUNT STATUS, MUTUAL GROUPS AND COUNTRY

Meta to explain why action should not be initiated under the Information Technology Act and the Information Technology Rules, 2021, if the proposed feature is found to increase cybercrime risks. The notice refers to provisions including Section 79 of

the IT Act dealing with intermediary due diligence obligations, Rules 3 and 4 of the IT Rules governing intermediary responsibilities and identification of the first originator of messages, as well as Sections 66C and 66D covering identity theft and cheating by personation through computer resources. It also cites Section 79(3)(a), which relates to intermediary liability for aiding, abetting or inducing unlawful acts. "In this regard, you are directed to furnish a detailed explanation, supported by relevant documents, on this new feature, within three days of its receipt," the notice said. The government has also instructed Meta not to launch the feature in India until consultations

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House committee may retain Bill to sack CMs, Mins jailed for 30 days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill is expected to adopt its report on July 17, clearing the way for the proposed legislation to be taken up during the Monsoon Session of Parliament, likely to begin on July 20. The Bill seeks to remove the prime minister, chief minister or any other minister from office if they remain in custody for 30 consecutive days in connection with an offence punishable with imprisonment of five years or more. While the committee is expected to recommend safeguards against political misuse, sources said it is likely to retain the provision that has triggered the strongest opposition.

TAKEAWAYS

- » JPC likely to adopt Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill report on July 17
- » Bill expected in Monsoon Session, likely beginning July 20
- » Proposal removes ministers after 30 consecutive custody days in serious criminal cases
- » BILL COVERS OFFENCES PUNISHABLE WITH IMPRISONMENT OF FIVE YEARS OR MORE

The proposed law states that once a minister completes 30 consecutive days in custody for a qualifying offence, removal from office would take

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Quick News

VB-G RAM G ACT COMES INTO FORCE

NEW DELHI: The Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 came into force nationwide on Wednesday, guaranteeing eligible rural households 125 days of wage employment instead of 100. The Centre allocated Rs 95,692.31 crore for implementation and raised the national average daily wage from Rs 298.8 to Rs 327.4, with no wage below Rs 300. Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan called it a "historic day for rural India."

See P6

FOREIGN SECRETARY VIKRAM MISRI GETS ONE YEAR EXTENSION

NEW DELHI: Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri was given a one-year extension on Wednesday, till July 14 next year. Widely regarded as an expert on China, Misri was appointed to the post in June 2024. The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet has approved the extension for a period of one year beyond July 14, 2026, that is, up to July 14, 2027, under the provisions of Fundamental Rule 56(d). The rule has a provision for extension in service for the defence secretary, foreign secretary, home secretary, director of the Intelligence Bureau, secretary of Research and Analysis Wing, and a few others beyond the age of retirement of 60 years.

Continued on P6

KHARGE, NITIN NABIN INVITED TO KHAMENEI'S LAST RITES

NEW DELHI: Iran has invited BJP president Nitin Nabin and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge to attend the funeral of late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Tehran, according to reports. Congress leaders Salman Khurshid and Pawan Khara have also received invitations. Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita and Bihar Governor Lt Gen (Retd) Syed Ata Hasnain are expected to represent the Indian government at the ceremony on July 4. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was invited by Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian last week, though officials consider his participation unlikely. Iran has also invited leaders from China, Russia, Pakistan and Qatar. Pakistan Prime Minister

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Four months later, no US reckoning for strike that killed schoolchildren

US strike on school killed hundreds, we still don't know full story

ASSOCIATED PRESS

JERUSALEM: It was the deadliest reported strike in the US-Israeli war against Iran, and most of the victims were children. Yet over four months since a US missile struck an Iranian primary school, there is no final accounting of what happened. The Trump administration has not directly accepted the blame, though the military possessed evidence almost immediately that the site had been struck, a US official with knowledge of the situation, speaking anonymously to discuss an ongoing investigation, told The Associated Press. Drawing from interviews with US officials, human rights workers and Iranians in direct contact with rescuers and fami-



CLOSER LOOK

» Most victims were children: Airwars identified 157 dead, including 123 children and 34 adults

» No final death toll: Authorities and investigators still lack a complete accounting of the victims

» US military knew early: Officials had evidence soon after the strike that a school had been hit

lies of victims, the AP reconstructed the strike and its aftermath to reveal new details of what happened. Most requested anonymity for fear

of retribution against them and their sources. Details remain elusive. When asked last week about the strike,

Continued on P6

MONSOON BATTERS SEVERAL STATES

Heavy rains trigger landslides, flooding; 7 dead

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Heavy monsoon rain caused widespread destruction across several states on Wednesday, leaving at least seven people dead in Himachal Pradesh and Karnataka, while floods, landslides and waterlogging disrupted transport, damaged infrastructure and affected daily life.

Fresh weather warnings were also issued for several regions as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecast more intense rainfall over the coming days. In Himachal Pradesh, four people died in rain-related incidents after heavy showers lashed Shimla, Manali, Dharamshala and other areas. The southwest monsoon, which entered the state on

Tuesday, covered the entire region by Wednesday. The weather office in Shimla issued an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rainfall at isolated places from July 2 to July 6, except July 4. A woman from Solan district lost her life after a boulder struck her when she stepped out of her car on the Chandigarh-Manali National Highway near

Aut. According to the State Emergency Operations Centre (SEOC), three other deaths were reported in Kangra district, including one caused by electrocution and another due to a fall from height. Heavy rain also created flood-like conditions in Lanot and Phagdog villages in Chamba district, where debris from a hillside crashed into

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Centre asks Delhi Gymkhana Club why it should not be evicted, seeks reply by July 7

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre has initiated eviction proceedings against the Delhi Gymkhana Club by issuing a show cause notice asking why it should not be removed from its premises under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971. The notice, dated June 29, was issued by Estate Officer Bipin Kumar Singh of the Land and Development

Office (L&DO), which functions under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs. It directs the Delhi Gymkhana Club and all others occupying the property to file their response by July 7 and attend a personal hearing on the same day at 2.30 pm. The action comes more than a month after the Centre informed the Delhi High Court on May 26 that it would not take forceful possession of the 27.3 acre property by June 5.

Continued on P6

ATF, commercial LPG prices cut as softer oil eases costs

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Aviation turbine fuel (ATF) and commercial LPG prices were reduced on Wednesday after easing tensions in West Asia brought down international crude oil prices. Private fuel retailer Nayara Energy also cut petrol and diesel prices, becoming the first fuel retailer in more than two years to lower pump rates.

Nayara lowers petrol, diesel rates

Industry sources said ATF prices were reduced by about Rs 5 per litre, taking the price for domestic airlines in Delhi to around Rs 110 per litre. This is the first reduction after prices had risen sharply during the recent conflict in West Asia.

Continued on P6

Eight killed, 24 injured as bus catches fire after crashing into truck

MPOST BUREAU

JAIPUR: Eight people were killed and 24 others were injured after a passenger bus crashed into a truck and caught fire on the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway in Rajasthan's Dausa district early Wednesday, police said. The accident took place near Dhanawda under the Kolwa police station area. According to Dausa Superintendent of Police Piyush Dixit, six passengers were burnt alive while two died from severe head injuries. "The bus belonging to Hans Travels was travelling from Rishikesh to Indore when it hit a truck moving ahead

Continued on P6



Organisation in Special Consultative Status with the United Nations Economic & Social Council (UN-ECOSOC)

KALINGA INSTITUTE OF INDUSTRIAL TECHNOLOGY

KIIT Deemed to be University
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Slow and Steady Wins the Race...

Times Higher Education Sustainability Impact Ratings 2026

IMPACT GLOBAL RANKING 2026 **101-200** Cohort

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SDGs	India Rank	Global Rank
10 REDUCED INEQUALITIES	1	16
14 LIFE BELOW WATER	1	45
16 PEACE, JUSTICE AND STRONG INSTITUTIONS	1	46
9 INDUSTRY, INNOVATION AND INFRASTRUCTURE	2	54
15 LIFE ON LAND	2	56
8 DECENT WORK AND ECONOMIC GROWTH	3	201-300
11 SUSTAINABLE CITIES AND COMMUNITIES	3	101-200
17 PARTNERSHIPS FOR THE GOALS	3	101-200

SDGs	India Rank	Global Rank
2 ZERO HUNGER	4	43
6 CLEAN WATER AND SANITATION	4	32
7 AFFORDABLE AND CLEAN ENERGY	4	17
13 CLIMATE ACTION	4	60

SDGs	India Rank	Global Rank
4 QUALITY EDUCATION	5	34
5 GENDER EQUALITY	5	45
12 RESPONSIBLE CONSUMPTION AND PRODUCTION	5	101-200
1 NO POVERTY	6	101-200
3 GOOD HEALTH AND WELL-BEING	8	201-300

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Reduced inequalities	401-600 th Cohort

About SDGs - The Times Higher Education Sustainability Impact Ratings is the only global ranking measuring how institutions worldwide advance sustainability in line with the United Nation's Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

📍 KIIT-DU, Patia, Bhubaneswar, Odisha, India 751024 ✉ kiit@kiit.ac.in 🌐 www.kiit.ac.in

KIIT (Deemed to be University) has only one permanent campus in Bhubaneswar, Odisha. It has no other campus / off campus anywhere else in the country and globe.

BOTH LEADERS APPEAR MOST DIVERGENT ON MIDDLE EAST

Vance, Rubio take different approaches as Iran tests their 2028 prospects

WASHINGTON: Vice President JD Vance and Secretary of State Marco Rubio appear to be staking out differing approaches to carrying out President Donald Trump's national security agenda as the possible 2028 presidential rivals jostle for position in a divided Republican Party.

With vastly different backgrounds and policy experience, they have moved along separate paths to stake out territory: Rubio, the son of Cuban immigrants with a long history in the Senate and major interest in Latin America, and Vance, a child of the Midwest and Marine Corps veteran who served in the Senate for only two years before being tapped as Trump's 2024 running mate, with a message of opposing foreign wars.

While deferential to each other — and with the White House and State Department denying any suggestion of a rift



Vice President JD Vance and Secretary of State Marco Rubio



— Vance and Rubio appear the most divergent on the Middle East.

In discussing Iran, Vance has several times been critical of Israel and its actions in Lebanon, saying Trump has been frustrated by Israeli actions against the Iranian-backed militant group Hezbollah that have angered Iran and made negotiations with Tehran more difficult. Rubio, meanwhile, has

remained supportive of Israel or held his tongue, particularly over the situation in Lebanon — an issue he has taken the lead on and resulted in a preliminary framework agreement last week.

"The talk about differences is not idle speculation," said Dan Fried, a former assistant secretary of state and ambassador to Poland who is now with the Atlantic Council, a Washington

Highlights

- » Rubio has remained supportive of Israel or held his tongue
- » Vance takes the lead on Iran negotiations and Rubio on Lebanon
- » Vance sees an opportunity to burnish his foreign policy credentials

to ensure Iran can never possess a nuclear weapon," White House spokeswoman Anna Kelly said.

State Department spokesman Tommy Pigott added that "Rubio and the entire administration is 100% in lockstep behind President Trump."

Yet, according to Trump administration officials familiar with the matter, Rubio was so skeptical of obtaining an acceptable deal with Iran that he declined to head the US delegation to the first ceasefire negotiations in April in Islamabad, Pakistan.

Vance, however, seeing an opportunity to burnish his foreign policy credentials, jumped on it, asking Trump twice to take the lead before Trump agreed, according to the officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss internal administration deliberations.

AGENCIES

think tank. "There is definitely something to it."

The White House fired back at any suggestions of a rift.

"Why is the legacy media obsessed with driving a wedge between Vice President Vance and Secretary Rubio that does not exist?"

There is one camp — President Trump's camp — and the entire administration is fully behind the president's efforts

Trump flies in new Air Force One, gift from Qatar

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Wednesday took the first flight in the newly refurbished Air Force One jet, previously owned by Qatar, which gifted it to be inducted in the presidential fleet of aircraft.

The red, white and navy blue livery of the Boeing 747-8i luxury jet replaces the robin's egg blue exterior of the old aircraft that ferried presidents since George H W Bush during its nearly 40-year tenure.

The tail of the aircraft features a wavy US national flag. "For me, this is the first flight of what I think is maybe the greatest commercial plane ever built... to be honest with you, I'm excited about the first flight," Trump told reporters at the Joint Base Andrews near here as he travels to North Dakota to inaugurate the Theodore Roosevelt Presidential Library.

AGENCIES

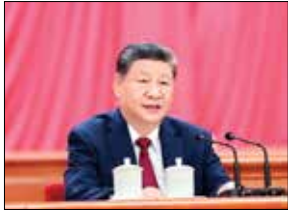
Xi directs PLA to speed up modernisation

BEIJING: President Xi Jinping on Wednesday directed the military to speed up the goal of elevating its capabilities to world-class standards to protect China's sovereignty and development interests.

Xi, who heads the ruling Communist Party of China (CPC), the military and the Presidency, made the remarks at a gathering to celebrate the party's 105th founding anniversary, during which he asked the People's Liberation Army (PLA) to accelerate its modernisation process.

He called for efforts to achieve the goals set for the military's 100th anniversary in 2027 and elevate the armed forces' capabilities to world-class standards, which is widely interpreted as matching the standards of the US military in weaponry, equipment and training.

Xi also called for efforts



Chinese President Xi Jinping

to resolutely safeguard China's sovereignty, security and development interests, and make greater contributions to safeguarding world peace and development, state-run Xinhua news agency reported.

He also spoke of China's "unshakable" commitment to unify Taiwan with the Chinese mainland.

Resolving the Taiwan question and realising China's complete reunification is a historic mission and an unshakable commitment for the CPC, he said.

AGENCIES

US, Canada, Mexico review trade pact

WASHINGTON: Tourists from Chattanooga check into beach resorts in Cancun. Canadian auto parts feed factories in the American Midwest — and vice versa. Happy Hour revelers raise glasses of Mexican tequila and mezcal at bars in Seattle.

It adds up. The United States trades \$1.9 trillion a year — \$5 billion a day — worth of goods and services with its neighbours, Canada and Mexico. They have supplanted China as America's top two trading partners.

So the stakes are high when it comes to fiddling with the rules that govern trade between the three countries. And after a year of President Donald Trump's cha-

otic tariff policies, many US, Canadian and Mexican businesses would welcome the return of stability across North America.

They are not likely to get it. The regional trade pact — the US-Mexico-Canada Agreement or USMCA — that Trump negotiated and boasted about in his first term comes up for renewal Wednesday, a process that is likely to last months, maybe longer.

"There's going to be a lot of drama this summer," Diego Marroquin Bitar, a fellow in the America's program at the Center for Strategic and International Studies, said last week at a USMCA forum sponsored by the Cato Institute.

AGENCIES

Ukraine hits Russian oil refinery for 2nd time in week: Zelenskyy

The Ufa refinery is one of Russia's largest producers of lubricants

KYIV: Ukrainian forces struck Russia's major Ufa oil refinery for the second time in a week, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Wednesday.

Almost daily long-range attacks on Russian oil facilities have created a fuel crisis and heaped political pressure on the Kremlin as its all-out invasion of Ukraine stretches into its fifth year.

The Ufa refinery is one of Russia's largest producers of lubricants and is located more than 1,000 kilometres from Ukraine, Zelenskyy said on social media.

Ukraine also struck a plant producing missile components in Russia's



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy

Penza region southeast of Moscow, some 500 kilometres from Ukraine, Zelenskyy said.

Russian officials did not confirm the strikes, which could not be independently verified.

The Russian Defence Ministry reported intercepting 179 Ukrainian

Many regions of Russia, one of the world's biggest energy producers, have introduced fuel rationing

drones over 16 Russian regions, the annexed Crimea and waters of the Azov and the Black Sea.

Penza Gov Oleg Melnichenko said only that downed drone debris damaged a power line and fell on a building under construction. Ukraine's domes-

tically developed and manufactured drones and missiles have been hammering Russian oil facilities, including refineries, terminals, storage depots and pipeline pumping stations, for months.

Many regions of Russia, one of the world's biggest energy producers, have introduced fuel rationing.

Ukraine has developed new weaponry and in recent months has gained an edge, according to Western officials.

Its strikes on supply routes behind the front line have robbed the Russian army of momentum on the battlefield, officials and analysts say.

AGENCIES

Racism, intolerance have worsened in Britain: Starmer

LONDON: UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer said on Wednesday that racism and intolerance had worsened in Britain over the past decade, warning it was damaging social cohesion and deterring people from public life.

He spoke a day after a Reuters report found some Britons of colour fear a resurgence of racism linked to anti-migrant rhetoric and a political focus on crime, following recent unrest including protests in Southampton after the murder of Henry Nowak and rioting in Belfast after a stabbing attack.

Facing questions in parliament, Starmer said "racism and intolerance is permeating everywhere."

The British leader was responding to a lawmaker who said he was worried that racism and the incitement of violence linked to it were being normalised, including by some politicians.

"We have to deal with it, because it's tearing our societies apart," Starmer said, adding that "it should be called out by every single person who is a politician at any level in this country."

Starmer recalled the 2016 death of Labour lawmaker Jo Cox, an active supporter of immigration and social cohesion, who was killed by a far-right extremist days before the Brexit referendum.

He said that when reflecting recently upon her death he felt things had got worse, not better, in the intervening decade.

Tuesday's Reuters report cited warnings from trade unions and professional bodies about rising racist abuse in workplaces and public life, alongside heightened tensions following the unrest across the United Kingdom.



UK PM Keir Starmer

Takeaways

» Facing questions in parliament, Starmer said 'racism and intolerance is permeating everywhere'

» Nigel Farage, the leader of populist party Reform UK, has accused British institutions of discriminating against white people

STARMER RECALLED THE 2016 DEATH OF LABOUR LAWMAKER JO COX

Nigel Farage, the leader of populist party Reform UK, has accused British institutions of discriminating against white people, arguing they were biased by policies aimed at supporting ethnic minorities. Starmer has rejected those claims. Addressing the tone of political debate, Starmer said:

"That's on us to fix — every single member of this house, whatever their party is and anybody who inflames it should be absolutely ashamed of themselves." AGENCIES

Syria names first Parliament after Assad's fall

DAMASCUS: The first Parliament in Syria's post-Assad era took shape Wednesday with the release of a list of 70 legislators picked up by interim President Ahmad al-Sharaa.

The inauguration of the new Parliament shows the country is moving ahead with drafting laws as the nation works on recovering from decades of iron-fist rule under the Assad family and a deadly war that has killed about half a million people.

The head of Syria's electoral committee, Mohammed Taha al-Ahmad, told reporters that the new 210-member legislature will hold its first meeting Monday. Members will be sworn in and the Parliament's presidential council will be elected. The list of 70 legislators picked by al-Sharaa included 15 women, which raised the number of female members in the legislature to 22. Syria held the first phase of its parliamentary elections in October while excluding the southern province of Sweida.

AGENCIES

Marine heat wave caused seabird deaths off California

SAN DIEGO: Within minutes of walking on a San Diego beach, marine ornithologist Tammy Russell found the feathered carcasses — one after another.

Some were mixed in with washed up kelp. Others were under rocks.

Each month, scientists and volunteers conduct surveys of dead seabirds and find what Russell describes as a grim assessment of the impact of a massive marine heat wave that has lingered for months off parts of the California coast.

The surveys that have been carried out by various organisations for decades help build a baseline of information on beached sea life to detect threats and their impact.

Many seabirds, including California brown pelicans, loons and grebes, starved to death in recent months as

Scientists fear the die-off could worsen with the recently formed El Nino

record-setting ocean temperatures decreased the band of cold, nutrient-rich surface water where krill, anchovies and sardines thrive near the shore, said Russell, a post-doctoral scholar at the University of California, San Diego, Scripps Institution of Oceanography.

"We've been seeing cormorants walk to shore and then just die within the hour. I mean one time it happened within 15 minutes, and I've never seen that before," Russell said.

"That has been heartbreaking for me and we're seeing this happening across the whole coast."

AGENCIES

At least 13,000 tonnes of space junk clutters Earth orbit

More satellites means more space junk, which is already threatening critical infra we rely on every day

ADELAIDE: Seventy years ago, Earth had only one satellite: the Moon. Now it has more than 15,000 — about 10,000 of which are owned by Elon Musk's SpaceX. The world's first trillionaire plans to launch one million more satellites, each roughly 70 metres long and 20 metres wide, that would form a data centre megaconstellation.

But more satellites means more space junk, which is already threatening critical infrastructure we rely on every day.

Addressing this problem effectively requires work across three fronts: technology, policy and philosophy.



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Space junk is everything in Earth orbit that doesn't have a purpose. It includes discarded rocket bodies, defunct and broken satellites, and fragments down to nanoparticle size. There are

36,000 pieces of junk larger than ten centimetres and tens of millions of smaller pieces and particles.

The estimated weight of all of this junk is 13,486 tonnes, the equivalent of 13 million

“THE ESTIMATED WEIGHT OF ALL OF THIS JUNK IS 13,486 TONNES, THE EQUIVALENT OF 13 MILLION ADULT CANE TOADS”

adult cane toads. The United States, Russia (as well as the former USSR), and China are the biggest contributors.

Space junk is dangerous because it's orbiting at almost unimaginable speeds — 7 kilometres per second on average in low Earth orbit. A collision

can break up a satellite and create even more space junk.

The worst case scenario is called Kessler syndrome. Each collision creates space junk which collides with other space junk, in an endless cascade.

It could make regions of Earth orbit unusable, or possibly even cut Earth off from space.

Human spaceflight is already threatened by the debris around Earth.

The International Space Station manoeuvres to avoid collision at least once a year.

The default solution is to let space junk get dragged into the atmosphere where it incinerates. For example, at least one

Starlink satellite burns up in the atmosphere every day.

But this is now creating enough soot and alumina particles to have an impact on the ozone layer, which protects us from harmful ultraviolet radiation. Technological solutions involve active debris removal, and strategic satellite and mission design.

Active debris removal gets rid of old spacecraft by tipping them into the atmosphere or pushing them into a "graveyard" orbit which isn't used by functioning satellites.

There's even a hit list of the 50 most dangerous spacecraft — mainly abandoned rocket bodies.

AGENCIES

Ship runs aground in Hormuz: Reports



DUBAI: A ship ran aground in the Strait of Hormuz while using a route not approved by Iran, state television in Tehran reported Wednesday. The vessel was identified as a foreign container ship, with no other details.

The report appeared aimed at underlining Tehran's claims to control the strait, which the world has long considered an international waterway. A fifth of all oil and natural gas passed through it in peacetime.

Iran has used its ability to choke off the waterway as a key source of leverage since the war began Feb 28, disrupting global markets for energy and other critical goods.

The report came as US

Mideast envoy Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, US President Donald Trump's son-in-law, were in Doha, Qatar, for talks over reaching a permanent end to the Iran war. Iran's top negotiator, Kazem Gharibabadi, travelled to Qatar with a team as well.

Technical talks between diplomats began Wednesday in Qatar, said two regional officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss the closed-door discussions. Negotiators aim to nail down specifics to pave the way for top leaders to seal an agreement, though differences over the strait and Lebanon loom large.

AGENCIES



A DIVINE JOURNEY OF FAITH, STRENGTH & SPIRITUALITY



SHRI AMARNATH JI YATRA-2026



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WOMEN'S, CHILDREN'S SAFETY REMAINS TOP PRIORITY

L-G urges people-centric policing at Delhi Police Commissionerate Day

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Wednesday celebrated its Commissionerate Day with a ceremonial parade at the Parade Ground, New Police Lines, Kingsway Camp. Lieutenant Governor of Delhi Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu attended as the chief guest and took the ceremonial salute in the presence of Commissioner of Police Satish Golchha, IPS.

In his welcome address, Commissioner Golchha said Delhi Police has undergone a significant transformation, with greater emphasis on crime prevention and technology-driven policing.

Highlighting improvements in crime statistics, he said there has been a decline in heinous crimes, offences registered under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, thefts, crimes against



women and the use of firearms in heinous crimes.

Referring to the three-year Vision Document (2026–2029) under the Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyan, he said Delhi Police

has identified 123 narcotics hotspots through scientific analysis. He also announced that, in line with the Lieutenant Governor's directions, July will be observed as Child Safety

HIGHLIGHTS

» Referring to the three-year Vision Document (2026–2029) under the Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyan, he said Delhi Police has identified 123 narcotics hotspots through scientific analysis

» He also announced that, in line with the L-G's directions, July will be observed as Child Safety Awareness Month.

Addressing the gathering, the Lieutenant Governor said the occasion reflected the remarkable evolution of Delhi Police as a professional insti-

tution and congratulated all medal recipients. He urged the force to remain committed to the principles of "visible, humane, technology-driven and people-centric policing".

Quoting the Prime Minister's vision, he said policing must become "more professional, sensitive and responsive" while ensuring citizen-centric service delivery and remaining aligned with the national vision of Viksit Bharat.

He said ensuring the safety and security of Delhi, particularly of women and children, remains the foremost objective of Delhi Police.

Appreciating Operation Vishwas, he described community policing as a vital pillar of public-police partnership and called upon all stakeholders to work together towards making Delhi "the world's finest urban city".

Fire destroys goods worth crores at electronics store

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Electronic goods and other materials worth crores of rupees were destroyed in a fire at a multi-storey electronics showroom in Janakpuri around 4:15 am on Wednesday, officials said, reporting no casualties.

A Delhi Fire Service (DFS) officer said the blaze at the Vijay Sales showroom on the Uttam Nagar-Najafgarh Road prompted the deployment of 15 fire tenders.

Eyewitnesses said visuals from the scene showed thick black smoke billowing as flames rapidly engulfed the building, which was visible from a considerable distance.

The fire also spread to an adjoining Bata showroom, following which authorities cordoned off the area while firefighters worked to prevent the blaze from spreading further, police said.

The DFS officer said firefighters initially rushed three water tenders to the spot.



However, as the fire's intensity increased, more fire engines were pressed into service.

The DFS officer said the blaze was brought under control around 6:30 am, but cooling operations continued till evening to ensure it did not reignite. According to fire officials, the blaze engulfed electronic goods, furniture and other materials stored in the basement, ground floor and three upper floors of the building, spread over around 350 square yards.

"While the exact extent of the damage is being assessed, the blaze is believed to have gutted electronic goods and

other material worth crores of rupees," the DFS officer said. He said the exact cause of the fire is yet to be ascertained, and an investigation is underway.

As news of the fire spread, several worried customers rushed to the showroom carrying purchase bills and invoices, seeking information about products they had recently bought or were expecting to receive.

"It was shocking to hear, as I am a regular customer. All the branches are good," a customer who visited the spot said.

Another customer, Dinesh Joshi, said he had booked two air conditioners for Rs 71,700 at the showroom on Tuesday night and was expecting their delivery on Wednesday. Joshi expressed hope that the delivery would not be affected by the fire.

Police and fire officials remained at the scene while cooling operations continued, and they inspected the premises for structural damage.

Police nabs Tillu Tajpuria gang aide in Alipur firing case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two men, including an alleged associate of the Tillu Tajpuria gang, have been arrested in connection with a case in which around 30 to 45 armed assailants allegedly opened 12 rounds of fire while trying to forcibly grab a disputed property in outer-north Delhi's Alipur, police said on Wednesday.

The accused have been identified as Sandeep alias Daagu Maharaj (40) and Deepak (32), both residents of Sonapat in Haryana.

The police seized one semi-automatic pistol, eight live cartridges and a black SUV from them'.

The case pertains to an incident on October 30, 2025, when the group of armed men allegedly stormed a disputed plot in the Ramjanpur village, opened indiscriminate fire and assaulted several persons with lathis while attempting to break open the lock of the property.

A case under multiple provisions of the BNS and the Arms Act was subsequently registered at the Alipur police station.

According to the police, Sandeep is an active associate of the Tillu Tajpuria gang, while Deepak is his cousin. The police said a dedicated team acted on specific intelligence inputs suggesting that Sandeep, who was wanted in the case, would be arriving in the Narela area along with his associate with illegal weapons.

A trap was laid and the accused were intercepted near the road connecting UER-II Road and Alipur-Narela Road. They allegedly attempted to



'Police seized one semi-automatic pistol, 8 live cartridges, a black SUV from them'

flee, but were overpowered after a brief chase, the police said. During interrogation, Sandeep allegedly disclosed that he came into contact with gangster Tillu Tajpuria while lodged in Sonapat Jail between 2016 and 2022. He claimed Tajpuria recruited him into the gang and arranged weapons for him after his release in November 2022.

The police said Sandeep further revealed that in October 2025, he and his brother were allegedly called by gang associates to bring firearms for the forcible takeover of the Ramjanpur plot, where the firing took place.

Sandeep has previous involvement in at least six criminal cases, including murder and attempt to murder, while Deepak has been booked in four cases, including murder, illegal arms possession and NDPS offences, the police said.

A fresh case under the Arms Act has been registered at the Crime Branch police station in connection with the latest recovery.

Prostitution racket busted at Paharganj spa; owner arrested, four women rescued: Police

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has busted an alleged prostitution racket run under the guise of a spa in central Delhi's Paharganj area and arrested its owner-cum-manager following a decoy operation, an official said on Wednesday.

Four women, aged between 26 and 40 years, were rescued during the raid conducted at a spa on Panchkuian Road and their statements are being recorded to ascertain whether more persons were involved in the racket, they said.

The police received a tip-off on June 30 that human trafficking activities were



being carried out at the SIN Spa, located on the second floor of a building on Panchkuian Road, where customers were allegedly being lured for prostitution activities.

Acting on the tip-off, a raiding team sent a decoy customer inside the spa with pre-recorded currency notes worth Rs 2,000 to

verify the information. The police said the decoy customer was allegedly offered prostitution services by the spa operator, who accepted the advance payment and directed one of the women present at the premises to accompany him to a room.

After receiving a pre-decided signal, the police

Delhi Gymkhana Club row: Lease, staff concerns raised

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: With the future of the Delhi Gymkhana Club hanging in the balance ahead of the Delhi High Court hearing on July 28, questions are being raised over the handling of official notices issued by the Land & Development Office (L&DO).

Former club president Vijay Kumar Singh said the club had been under the control of a 15-member committee appointed by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, making it responsible for responding to every official communication. Referring to the reported notices concerning nearly Rs 48 crore in ground rent arrears and lease-related issues, he said such matters should have been addressed immediately. If any corrections or compliance requirements were

needed, they should have been resolved at the time, he said, adding that the committee must explain why the notices were not acted upon with the seriousness they warranted.

The club's legal counsel has also argued that the Gymkhana holds a perpetual lease with no limitation on its duration, making the validity of the lease termination one of the central issues before the court.

Echoing concerns over the government's move, club member and retired IPS officer B.L. Vohra, former Director General of Police, said the decision to reclaim the club was difficult to justify. Rejecting the perception that the Gymkhana is merely an elite institution, he said most members are retired civil servants and armed forces personnel who dedicated decades of service to the country. Ques-

tioning the security rationale, he noted that the club has stood at the same location for decades, including when former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi lived across the road, and asked why security concerns had surfaced only now.

The uncertainty has also drawn attention to the livelihoods of the club's employees, including waiters, cooks, gardeners, cleaners and other ground staff, many of whom have spent decades serving the institution and live within its premises. Any disruption to the club's functioning could leave them unemployed, with little clarity over their housing, separation benefits or future rehabilitation.

Members also said Delhi's shrinking green spaces deserve careful consideration. They argued that open spaces such as the Gymkhana play an

important environmental role and should not be replaced by large-scale construction without a well-defined master plan. Referring to the Jaipur Polo Club, where a government takeover has reportedly been followed by plans for construction, they said similar decisions should be guided by a long-term vision rather than isolated actions.

Questions are also likely to be raised over why institutions occupying even larger tracts of government land, such as the Delhi Golf Club, are not facing similar action. As the matter heads for its next hearing, issues relating to the reported lease notices, administrative accountability, the status of the perpetual lease, the future of employees and the government's long-term plans for the land are expected to remain at the centre of the case.

Main accused held in assault that killed 16-yr-old student

Ghaziabad: Teen abducted & assaulted after minor road accident

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: Police on Wednesday arrested the main accused in the alleged murder of a 16-year-old Class 10 student, who died after being brutally assaulted following a minor road accident in Loni earlier this week. The second accused remains absconding, and three police teams have been formed to trace him.

The accused, Rahul, a resident of Tila Shahbazzpur village, was arrested near the Behta pipeline area, police said. An FIR was registered at the Loni Border police station on a complaint lodged by the victim's elder brother, Shakir, against Rahul and an unidentified accomplice.

DCP (Rural) Surendra Nath Tiwari said multiple teams are conducting raids to arrest the remaining accused. "The investigation is progressing, and efforts are underway to ensure all those involved are brought to justice," he said.

According to the complaint, the victim, Zaid alias Sharik, a resident of Mustafabad Colony and a Class 10 student, had gone to a swimming pool in Behta Hajipur with his friends, Nadeem and Ibrahim, at around 3 pm on Monday.

While returning, their motorcycle allegedly brushed against a blue car on the Behta Hajipur canal road. Enraged over the minor collision, the car driver allegedly stopped the boys, slapped Zaid repeatedly, forced him into the vehicle and took him to a nearby property



The victim's friends followed the car to the office, where they allegedly found Rahul and another man abusing Zaid: Cops

dealer's office.

The victim's friends followed the car to the office, where they allegedly found Rahul and another man abusing Zaid. By then, the teenager was lying unconscious on the floor. The accused allegedly threatened the two boys with dire consequences and ordered them to take their friend away.

Unable to get any help, the boys took Zaid out of the office and, with the assistance of an e-rickshaw, brought him home. His family rushed him to Delhi's Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital, where doctors declared him dead. Following a post-mortem examination on Tuesday, the body was handed over to the family and buried at a cemetery in Mustafabad Colony. Police said the investigation is continuing and further arrests are expected.

DU receives 82,940 UG applications

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi University (DU) has recorded an overwhelming response to undergraduate admissions for the 2026–27 academic session, with 82,940 students completing registration through the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) within just four days of the admission portal opening.

The University commenced the UG admission and counselling process on June 26 through its online portal and is conducting admissions for 73 undergraduate programmes offered across its affiliated colleges. With nearly 72,000 undergraduate seats available, the early registration figures point to intense competition among applicants.

University officials have advised candidates who appeared for CUET UG 2026 to complete CSAS Phase-I registration within the prescribed timeline, stating that applicants who fail to register



Following CUET UG results, registered applicants will move to the college and course preference stage

during this stage will not be eligible for seat allocation.

Once CUET UG results are announced, registered candidates will move to CSAS Phase-2, where they will be required to submit preferences for colleges and courses. Seat allocation will be carried out based on CUET scores, programme eligibility, reservation policy and availability of seats.

The detailed schedule for Phase-2 is expected to be released shortly and the next stage of admissions is likely to begin in the first week of July.

The University is also expected to announce its academic calendar in the coming days. Although there are indications that colleges may reopen toward the end of July, no official confirmation has been issued. Meanwhile, several DU colleges have started releasing fourth-year registration notices on their respective websites for eligible students.

Students facing difficulties during the admission process have been advised to consult the official admission bulletin for guidelines. DU authorities are also working to resolve a technical issue related to verification of certain applicants' details with the National Testing Agency (NTA). With registrations already exceeding available seats, the coming phases of admissions are expected to witness heightened competition.

July 6–13: JNU announces registration schedule for Monsoon Semester 2026

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) has issued the registration schedule for the Monsoon Semester 2026, with the process set to take place from July 6 to 13. According to the Office of the Controller of Examinations, students must complete physical registration and deposit the prescribed fee at the time of registration.

The University has permitted the add-and-drop of courses until July 31 and advised students to verify their academic portfolio before attending classes, after which no changes will be allowed.

Students unable to register within the stipulated period may do so later by paying a daily late fee in the case of Indian students, while international students will be charged a percentage of their tuition fee depending on the delay.

Students have also been directed to clear all pending tuition, hostel and mess dues and obtain no-dues certificates before registration. JNU has further made the Academic Bank of Credit (ABC)/APAAR ID mandatory for students admitted from the 2021–22 academic session onwards.

Child Safety Month begins



NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has launched a two-day Training of Trainers (ToT) programme for teachers as part of the Child Safety Month initiative, aimed at strengthening child protection across educational institutions in the national capital.

The initiative, envisioned by Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, is being implemented jointly by the Directorate of Education (DoE), the State Council of Educational Research and Training (SCERT) and Delhi Police.

Held at the Aadarsh Audi-

torium at Police Headquarters, the programme is being conducted in hybrid mode across four half-day batches. The training covers the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) guidelines, school safety and security, cyber safety, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012, and its implementation in schools. Supervised by DCP/SPUWAC Neha Yadav, the programme aims to build awareness, promote child-friendly practices and strengthen child protection mechanisms in schools. **MP05T**

Woman labourer electrocuted while working construction site

NEW DELHI: A 25-year-old woman labourer died after she was electrocuted while working at an under-construction house in northwest Delhi's Tri Nagar area, police said on Wednesday. The deceased, identified as Sangeeta, a resident of Zakira, was rushed to Deep Chand Bandhu Hospital, where doctors declared her brought dead. Police said she suffered an electric shock while carrying out construction work at the site in Narang Colony.

An FIR has been registered at Keshav Puram Police Station under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita relating to negligence. Police are investigating whether adequate safety measures were in place and are verifying the roles of the house owner, contractor and others. **MP05T**

DELHI GOVT NOTIFIES DELHI EV POLICY 2026

FUTURE, FULLY CHARGED

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push towards tackling air pollution and accelerating the transition to clean mobility, the Delhi government on Wednesday formally notified the Delhi Electric Vehicle Policy, 2026, unveiling an ambitious roadmap that combines financial incentives, mandatory electrification targets, charging infrastructure, battery recycling and digital governance to transform the Capital's transport ecosystem by 2030.

The policy, which came into effect on July 1, 2026, will remain in force till March 31, 2030. It follows Cabinet approval on June 29 and seeks to significantly increase electric vehicle adoption while reducing dependence on conventional fuel-powered vehicles.

Announcing the policy, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "The policy aims to accelerate the adoption of electric vehicles across Delhi, improve air quality, reduce dependence on

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The policy, which came into effect on July 1, 2026, will remain in force till March 31, 2030
- » The policy aims to accelerate the adoption of electric vehicles across Delhi, improve air quality, reduce dependence on conventional fuels, significantly expand charging and battery swapping infrastructure and develop a robust

electric mobility ecosystem'

- » Under the policy, eligible electric two-wheelers will receive purchase incentives of up to Rs 30K in the first year, while electric auto-rickshaws will get incentives of up to Rs 50K



conventional fuels, significantly expand charging and battery swapping infrastructure and develop a robust electric mobility ecosystem." She added that it gives "equal emphasis to financial incentives, digital transparency, institutional oversight and environmental responsibility."

The policy cites the latest Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) report, which identifies vehicular emis-

sions as the largest contributor to Delhi's pollution, accounting for nearly 23 per cent of pollution during winter. With two-wheelers making up nearly 67 per cent of Delhi's vehicle population, the government has prioritised their electrification, along with three-wheelers, commercial vehicles and N1 category goods carriers.

Under the policy, eligible electric two-wheelers will

receive purchase incentives of up to Rs 30,000 in the first year, while electric auto-rickshaws will get incentives of up to Rs 50,000. Electric goods carriers will receive incentives of up to Rs.1 lakh, alongside scrapping incentives for replacing older BS-IV and below vehicles with electric alternatives. Electric vehicles will continue to enjoy exemption from road tax and registration fees, subject to prescribed conditions.

The policy also lays down phased electrification mandates. From January 1, 2027, only electric three-wheelers and N1 goods carriers will be eligible for new registration in Delhi, while from April 1, 2028, all newly registered two-wheelers must be electric. Schools have also been directed to progressively electrify their bus fleets, reaching 30 per cent electric buses by March 2030.

Chief Minister Gupta said, "The policy is not limited to encouraging the purchase of electric vehicles. Instead, it presents a comprehensive long-term

roadmap for clean mobility by integrating charging infrastructure, battery swapping, battery recycling, energy management, digital service delivery and environmental protection."

To oversee implementation, the government will establish a dedicated EV Cell under the Transport Department, constitute a High-Level Committee headed by the Chief Secretary, and create a Delhi EV Apex Committee. Delhi Transco Limited has been designated as the nodal agency for developing public charging and battery-swapping infrastructure, while the Environment Department and the Delhi Pollution Control Committee will oversee battery recycling and environmental compliance.

Calling it a transformative initiative, the Chief Minister said the new policy would play "a significant step towards cleaner air, modern transport, energy conservation and sustainable development" and help establish Delhi as a national model for electric mobility.

Winter pollution gets a rulebook

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major policy shift to tackle seasonal air pollution, the Delhi government on Wednesday notified a permanent Winter Pollution Master Plan that will automatically come into force every year from November 1 to February 28. The framework introduces a series of recurring measures, including denial of fuel to vehicles without valid Pollution Under Control (PUC) certificates, work-from-home norms, construction restrictions and stricter action against dust and waste burning.

The notification, issued by the Environment and Forest Department, consolidates multiple winter pollution orders into a single permanent framework. It is based on past air quality data, the revised Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) of the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) and directions of the Supreme Court.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "The new framework consolidates various existing orders into a single, clear and stringent system, making compliance easier for all concerned departments, institutions and citizens while ensuring more effective enforcement."

One of the key provisions makes it mandatory for all vehicles to possess a valid PUC certificate to obtain petrol, diesel, CNG or LPG at fuel stations across Delhi throughout the year. Authorities will verify compliance through digital databases in addition to physical certificates.

From November 1 to January 31, non-Delhi registered vehicles below BS-VI emission standards will not be allowed to enter the capital, except for exempted categories such as CNG and electric vehicles, ambulances, fire services and police vehicles.

To reduce traffic congestion, authorised parking charges will be doubled during the winter period, while DMRC parking facilities will remain exempt. During the same period, only 50 per cent of employees in

Permanent annual anti-smog plan to kick in every Nov 1



Delhi government and private offices will attend workplaces at a time, with the remaining staff working from home. Essential services, including health-care, public transport, power, water supply and sanitation, will remain exempt.

The government has also imposed an annual ban on demolition activities and dust-generating civil construction work from November 1 to January 31, while only essential public infrastructure projects will be permitted. Commercial buildings with a built-up area exceeding 3,000 square metres and construction sites larger than 1,000 square metres will be required to install anti-smog guns or mist systems.

The notification also introduces institutional accountability for open burning of waste, leaves and biomass, making Resident Welfare Associations, housing societies and institutions responsible for preventing such incidents within their premises.

Calling for public participation, Chief Minister Gupta said, "Making Delhi cleaner and healthier is not the responsibility of the Government alone but of every citizen." She added that the permanent framework would ensure all departments and citizens know in advance the pollution-control measures that will apply each winter.

Delhi govt sets Oct 31 deadline for ownership rights

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: Delhi government has fixed October 31 as the cut-off date to file applications to get conveyance deeds and authorisation slips needed for registry of properties in unauthorised colonies in the city, officials said.

No fresh applications would be accepted after the deadline, they said.

The move comes amid the revenue department receiving a low number of around 2,000 applications from residents of 1,511 unauthorised colonies for issuance of these documents.

A public notice issued on Wednesday stated that under the PM-UDAY Scheme (Pradhan Mantri Unauthorised Colonies Awas Adhikar Yojana), the Delhi government's revenue department has prescribed October 31, 2026, as the cut-off date for filing applications for grant of conveyance deeds and authorisation slips.

Conveyance deeds are issued for built-up properties on government land, and authorisation slips are issued for properties on private land in these unauthorised colonies. These documents are required to get a regularisation certificate from the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD).

In April, the Centre decided to regularise 1,511 unauthorised colonies in Delhi on an "as-is, where-is" basis without requiring approved layout plans. The revenue department has set up PM-UDAY Cells in each district magistrate's office for issuing conveyance deeds and authorisation slips. The sub-registrar offices of the revenue department register properties in unauthorised colonies based on these certificates.

On April 24, MCD's Swagam portal started accepting applications from residents who were issued conveyance deeds and authorisation slips. However, the number of applications remained low over the last two months, officials said.

They said that in view of the slow response to the scheme, the cut-off date could act as a stimulant and increase the number of applications.



Delhi backs ONOE

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining the Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, 2024, and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2024, on the proposed 'One Nation, One Election' framework held consultations with Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta during its visit to the national capital on Wednesday.

The delegation, led by JPC Chairman and MP P.P. Chaudhary, discussed the constitutional, legal and administrative implications of synchronising Lok Sabha and Assembly elections. The deliberations also covered electoral cycle integration, administrative preparedness and the possible impact on Delhi's governance framework.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta strongly supported the proposal, saying, "Holding simultaneous elections across the country is the need of the hour and there could be no better arrangement." She said conducting Lok Sabha and Assembly elections together would save "considerable time, energy and resources" while reducing repeated disruptions caused by the Model Code of Conduct.

Highlighting Delhi's experience, the Chief Minister said frequent elections divert government staff from essential public services, including education. She added, "If aligning election schedules at the national level requires a suitable adjustment in Delhi's tenure, the Delhi Govern-

Conducting Lok Sabha and Assembly elections together would save considerable time, energy and resources — CM

ment is willing to consider it with a positive approach." She further said the government would submit detailed written suggestions to the committee after studying all aspects of the proposed legislation. Addressing the committee at the Delhi Legislative Assembly, Speaker Vijender Gupta stressed that constitutional reforms should emerge through broad consultations. He observed that while simultaneous elections were common in the early decades after Independence, political developments led to separate electoral cycles over time.

He said, "Frequent elections entail substantial administrative and financial costs, repeatedly bring the Model Code of Conduct into operation and affect the continuity of governance and development programmes." He also underlined that "any reform must rest on broad political consensus and robust constitutional safeguards," while suggesting a detailed examination of issues such as constructive votes of no-confidence, premature dissolution of legislatures, harmonisation of electoral rolls and strengthening the Election Commission's logistical preparedness.

Nadda reviews dengue prep

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Health Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda on Wednesday chaired a high-level review meeting to assess Delhi's preparedness for preventing and controlling dengue, directing authorities to strengthen surveillance, hospital readiness and public awareness ahead of the peak transmission season.

The meeting reviewed the current dengue situation, preparedness of the Delhi government, municipal bodies and hospitals, as well as disease surveillance, vector control measures and clinical management protocols. Officials also presented a comprehensive action plan focusing on disease surveillance, mosquito control, early case detection, treatment and community awareness.

While noting that dengue incidence remains low and the mortality rate stands at 0.11

per cent, Nadda urged authorities not to lower their guard. He said, "The state and municipal bodies must proactively anticipate and prepare for any potential upsurge by clearly demonstrating their readiness."

Emphasising community participation, the Union minister called for an aggressive awareness campaign under the slogan "Jan Chetna through Jan Bhagidari". He asked authorities to organise special awareness drives in schools, labour camps and dengue-prone areas while involving Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs), ward commissioners and elected representatives in prevention efforts.

Nadda directed officials to intensify vector control in areas reporting increased fever cases, strengthen entomological surveillance to identify hotspots and expand fever surveillance across affected localities. He also instructed authorities to

ensure hospitals maintain dedicated dengue wards, adequate beds, blood components, diagnostic facilities, medicines and insecticides.

The minister further asked Sentinel Surveillance Hospitals and both public and private healthcare facilities to remain on alert and directed that all dengue cases be reported promptly through the Integrated Health Information Platform for Vector-Borne Diseases (IHIP-VBD). He also called for daily district-level review meetings and rapid response teams to respond quickly to any outbreak.

The meeting reviewed implementation of the National Strategy for Prevention and Control of Dengue, known as the "Octalogue", which is built around eight pillars, including surveillance, case management, vector control, outbreak response, capacity building and public awareness.

Delhi to build 27 new pucca schools at Rs 900 crore

NEW DELHI: Delhi government to construct 27 new pucca school buildings on vacant plots across the city for Rs 900 crore, with the project to be completed within 18 months in five cluster areas. The education department invited bids from Central government public sector undertakings for appointment as the project management consultant-cum-EPC agency to undertake the turnkey construction of the schools, according to a tender floated by the DoE.

To facilitate faster execution and monitoring, the 27 sites have been divided into five geographical clusters. These include six plots in Narela and Bawana, five in Bhalswa, Salempur Majra and Dariyapur Kalan, five in Rohini, Mundka and Sawda Ghevra, five in Shalimar Bagh, Bakkarwala, Hastal, Shyam Vihar and Nangli Vihar and six in Qutabapur, Kapashera, Jaffarpur, Jaunapur, Sabbari and Asola, it stated.

AGENCIES

CM launches Green Portal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday launched the Green Drive Portal, a digital platform aimed at encouraging public participation in tree plantation under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign, and said the initiative should become a people's movement.

The portal, greendrive.delhivannamahotsav.in, developed by the Delhi government's Department of Environment, Forest and Wildlife, allows residents to book plantation slots, request free saplings, locate government nurseries and register as "Green Warriors" to participate in environmental conservation activities.

Addressing the launch programme, Gupta said the initiative is not merely a government programme but a campaign that belongs to every resident of the national capital.

She urged every family to plant a tree under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign and



nurture it, saying every sapling planted would contribute to a greener and cleaner Delhi.

The chief minister said the government's objective is not only to plant trees but also to revive Delhi's natural ecosystem and build a cleaner, greener and healthier city for future generations.

She said the Ridge Forest Restoration Programme would be formally launched later this month by Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

According to a statement, the programme aims to plant 70 lakh saplings across Delhi and will adopt a scientific approach to restore the Ridge by creating a

three-tier forest structure using native, long-living species such as peepal, banyan, gular, neem, arjun and jamun to strengthen biodiversity, carbon sequestration and soil conservation.

The government also announced that 300 new electric buses would be flagged off as part of the programme and new inter-state routes will also be launched.

Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said the Green Drive Portal had identified plantation sites across all 70 Assembly constituencies, allowing citizens to book plantation slots at locations and times of their choice.

LATEST ONSET IN 5 YEARS: IMD

Monsoon expected in Capital within two days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi is likely to receive the southwest monsoon within the next two days, ending a prolonged wait and offering respite from the lingering summer heat. The arrival will mark the latest monsoon onset over the national capital in five years, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said on Wednesday.

The IMD on Wednesday said that conditions are favourable for the further advance of the southwest monsoon into more parts of the north Arabian Sea, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Punjab and parts of Rajasthan during the next two days.



People cover themselves due to scorching heat during summer season, in New Delhi, on Friday

PTI

The weather office said that the monsoon has further advanced into more parts of the north Arabian Sea and Gujarat, the entire Daman and Diu, more parts of Madhya Pradesh and

Uttar Pradesh, the remaining parts of Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Ladakh, the entire Jammu and Kashmir, and some parts of Haryana and Punjab on Wednesday.

"The northern limit of monsoon passes through Porbandar, Vallabh Vidyanagar, Shajapur, Naugaon, Mirzapur, Azamgarh, Ayodhya, Budaun, Meerut, Karnal and Gurdaspur on July 1," the IMD said.

According to the IMD, the southwest monsoon reached Delhi on June 25 in 2020, a day before it covered the entire country on June 26. In 2021, the monsoon arrived much later, reaching Delhi on July 13, the same day it covered the entire country.

In 2022, the monsoon advanced over Delhi on June 30 and covered the entire country on July 2. It reached the national capital on June 25, 2023, while the entire country came under monsoon conditions by July 2.

In 2024, the monsoon arrived in Delhi on June 28 and covered the whole country on July 2. Last year, the southwest monsoon reached Delhi on June 29, the same day it completed its advance over the entire country.

The IMD has forecast a generally cloudy sky with moderate rain for Delhi on Wednesday night and issued a yellow alert. Similar weather conditions are expected on Thursday. The maximum temperature is likely to settle around 33 degrees Celsius, while the minimum temperature is expected to be around 23 degrees Celsius.

No measurable rainfall was recorded between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm at any of Delhi's five weather stations on Wednesday. However, the 24-hour cumu-

lative rainfall till 8.30 am was recorded as a trace at Safdarjung, Palam and Ayanagar. Ridge recorded 0.2 mm of rainfall, while Lodhi Road recorded none. The maximum temperature ranged between 33.2 degrees Celsius and 34.8 degrees Celsius, remaining below normal across all five IMD stations.

Safdarjung, the city's base station, recorded a maximum temperature of 34.8 degrees Celsius, 2.6 degrees below normal. Palam recorded 33.6 degrees Celsius, 4.2 degrees below normal, while Lodhi Road recorded 33.7 degrees Celsius, 3.3 degrees below normal. Ridge and Ayanagar both recorded 33.2 degrees Celsius, which was 3.5 degrees and 4.9 degrees below normal, respectively.

City Briefs

MORE TIME FOR DDA FLATS

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has extended the booking period for flats under its Nagrik Awaas Yojana 2026 (First Come First Serve) till July 31, 2026, following demand from the general public for the housing units offered under the scheme. The scheme was launched through a circular dated January 23, 2026, offering High Income Group (HIG), Middle Income Group (MIG), Lower Income Group (LIG) and Economically Weaker Section (EWS) flats in Narela, along with LIG flats in Siraspur. In a subsequent circular issued on March 18, 2026, the DDA announced the addition of 1,944 flats in Sector G-7/G-8, Narela, over and above the flats already offered under the scheme. Booking for these newly added flats commenced on March 27, 2026. According to the latest circular, the extension of the booking period will allow prospective buyers to apply for both the previously offered flats and the newly added flats in Narela.

TRADE AND TAXES DEPT ISSUES DRESS CODE, WARNS AGAINST CASUAL ATTIRE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government's Trade and Taxes Department has directed all its officers and employees to adhere to a formal dress code and maintain professional conduct in offices, stressing that government workplaces must reflect discipline, dignity and public service values. In a circular issued by the department's Special Commissioner, officials have been instructed to wear decent, sober and appropriate attire during office hours. The order states that casual or inappropriate clothing that does not match the decorum of a government office should be avoided. The circular also emphasises that employees must report to work in a neat and presentable manner and maintain courteous behaviour while interacting with colleagues, visitors and members of the public.

MCD EXTENDS 10% PROPERTY TAX REBATE DEADLINE TILL JULY 31

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has extended the deadline for availing a 10 per cent rebate on lump-sum payment of property tax for the financial year 2026-27 from June 30 to July 31, Mayor Pravesh Wahi announced. The Mayor said the extension was aimed at giving more taxpayers an opportunity to benefit from the concession, particularly those who could not complete payments within the original timeline. According to the MCD, the move is expected to encourage timely tax compliance while also improving municipal revenue. The additional collections, the civic body said, would support expenditure on sanitation, healthcare, civic infrastructure and other public services across Delhi.

‘RURAL HOUSEHOLDS ENTITLED TO 125 DAYS’ EMPLOYMENT’

VB-G RAM G Act comes into force: Govt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Viksit Bharat -- Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025, came into force across the country on Wednesday, with the government saying the law will provide eligible rural households a statutory entitlement to 125 days of guaranteed wage employment.

In a statement, the Ministry of Rural Development said the Act aims to make rural employment more effective, transparent and outcome-oriented while focusing on the creation of durable rural assets, conservation of natural resources, improving agricultural productivity, livelihood promotion and women-led development.

The government also notified revised wage rates under the Act, with no notified daily wage being below Rs 300.

According to the ministry, the national average notified wage has increased from Rs



298.8 per day to Rs 327.4 per day, an average rise of over 10 per cent.

States such as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Assam, Arunachal Pradesh and Himachal Pradesh have witnessed wage increases ranging between 15 and 25 per cent, the statement said.

The Centre has released an interim allocation of Rs 95,692.31 crore to states and Union Territories for implementation of the scheme, including employment gen-

eration, timely wage payments and execution of development works, the ministry said.

Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan described the VB-G RAM G Act rollout as a “historic day for rural India”, saying that it was not merely a new law but a step towards securing the livelihood and dignity of rural workers.

“Eligible rural families will now have a statutory right to 125 days of employment instead of 100 days,” Chouhan said, adding that the govern-

ment’s priority was to ensure that no eligible rural worker is deprived of employment.

He said the Centre and states had completed administrative, financial and technical preparations for the implementation of the Act.

Chouhan expressed confidence that the new law would create livelihood opportunities, strengthen women’s empowerment and accelerate development in rural areas.

The national launch of the VB-G RAM G Act will be held on July 2 at Mukkavari-

palle village in Obulavaripalle mandal of Tirupati district in Andhra Pradesh.

Chouhan, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu and Deputy Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan are scheduled to attend the event.

The programme will include the formal launch of the scheme, distribution of Rural Employment Guarantee Cards to beneficiaries, launch of the VB-G RAM G software platform, release of publications and interaction with beneficiaries, the ministry said.

Highlights

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Japan PM Takaichi arrives in Delhi

Delighted to host you on your first visit to India, says PM Modi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi arrived in New Delhi on Wednesday on a three-day visit to India, during which she will hold talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi to strengthen bilateral cooperation across trade, investment, defence and other key sectors.

This is Takaichi’s first official visit to India. She is visiting at Modi’s invitation from July 1 to 3 for the 16th India-Japan annual summit, the MEA earlier said.

Takaichi posted on X photos of her arrival in India.

Sharing her post, Modi wrote: “A very warm welcome to India, Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi”

“We are delighted to host you on your first visit to India, and I look forward to our wide-ranging discussions tomorrow that will further deepen the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership. Through

our joint efforts, we will continue to advance peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond. @takaichi_sanae,” he said. According to a media advisory issued by the MEA on June 30, Takaichi will meet Modi at the Hyderabad House on Thursday.

Earlier, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal posted on X about her arrival in Delhi and said her visit marks an important step in taking the bilateral ties forward.

“Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi! A very warm welcome to Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi of Japan, who arrives in New Delhi on an Official Visit. PM Takaichi was received by MoS @ DrJitendraSingh,”

“The visit marks an important step in taking forward the Special Strategic and Global Partnership between India and Japan,” he said.

He also shared some photos of her arrival.

National Doctors Day: Nadda pays tribute to doctors, health-care workforce

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: On National Doctors Day, Union Minister for Health & Family Welfare, Jagat Prakash Nadda paid tribute to doctors and the entire health-care workforce, acknowledging their selfless service, unwavering dedication, and commitment to the wellbeing of society.

He said the occasion is an opportunity to honour not only doctors but every health-care worker who dedicates their life to others with compassion, commitment, and sacrifice.

Extending his heartfelt gratitude to the medical fraternity, Nadda appreciated its exemplary professionalism, unwavering dedication, and compassionate service to humanity. He also conveyed his best wishes for the continued success, good health, and wellbeing of doctors and healthcare professionals across the country.

Four months later, no US reckoning for strike that killed...

Continued from Page 1

President Donald Trump said he had seen nothing to make him believe the US was responsible. Iran’s mission to the United Nations did not respond to the AP’s request for comment.

Skies over the city of Minab were clear the morning of Saturday, Feb. 28. Students jostled into the Shajareh Tayyeb school, one of many across Iran established for children of families tied to Iran’s paramilitary Revolutionary Guard or other state institutions, said Shiva Amelirad, the international representative for an Iranian teachers union who taught in Iran for 18 years and has been in contact with people in Minab.

Though most schools in Iran operate within guidelines proscribed by the Islamic Republic, the Shejareh Tayyeb schools were more explicitly oriented toward reproducing and reinforcing the Guard’s worldview, she said, adding: “Regardless of the students’ family backgrounds, children are civilians and any attack targeting a school is unequivocally condemnable.”

The building lay within the same compound as a Guard base, according to an AP assessment of satellite imagery. It was a Guard building before it was fenced off and converted over a decade ago.

Some of its students were the children of Guard officers. Others were local kids from an area populated by people of a majority-Sunni ethnic minority known as the Baluch, often repressed by the Iranian government, said a local rights group.

Hundreds of students were inside when bombs began falling on Tehran. School staff began calling parents, summoning them for an early pickup, said two people.

One father living nearby rushed to pick up his son, said the resident of Minab, who relayed several families’ stories. He noticed young relatives waiting for their parents, said the resident. They declined his offer of a ride home.

Ten minutes later, bombs hit at least five buildings in the compound, according to satellite imagery. At least one collapsed the neighbouring school.

The father raced back to the chaos at the school, where men pawed through smoking rubble to dig out the bodies, according to video of the aftermath circulated by state media. He saw

burned bodies he believed were his relatives.

Rescuers found a tiny arm, suspended in the rubble. One man from a nearby Sunni village arrived to search for his nephew. In the rubble, he found him dead.

Bodies arrived at the local hospital in pieces, said the Balochistan Human Rights Group. By the end of the day, doctors at the hospital estimated they had at least 108 bodies, but cautioned that it was likely an undercount, said the resident of Minab.

Soon, state media was reporting a toll of 168.

Racing to document the ongoing bombardment, journalists and rights groups struggled to verify details from Minab. Government restrictions in Iran prevented most foreign journalists from entering the country. Iran had shut down the internet. The Strait of Hormuz became a major battlefield. All branches of Iran’s military deployed heavily in the area, said the resident, heightening fears among families of the victims about speaking out.

With details of the death toll elusive, researchers homed in on the question of responsibility. Iran blamed the US Trump blamed Iran. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said the Pentagon was investigating.

Internally, the US military knew more than it initially let on.

After the blast, the US military knew they had conducted strikes in the vicinity — though it took time to verify Iranian claims that a school was struck and begin an investigation, said the US official. It appears that the building housing the school was identified as such by one analyst as early as seven years ago, but that discovery was not sufficiently made known across different intelligence and military staffs and agencies; the building was not known among target developers as a school, revealing potential systematic shortfalls in the target analysis and review process, they said.

Much of the investigative work has been completed and the military is currently reviewing the findings.

Still, there is no full list of the dead.

The most extensive attempt comes from Air wars, which has identified the names and identities of 157 of the dead, including 123 children and 34 adults. Among the adults are 26 school staff members and five parents — each of whom lost at least one child in the strike.

From Page 1

Centre orders

are completed “to the satisfaction of the Government.”

Officials are simultaneously reviewing whether the existing legal framework provides adequate powers to restrict the rollout if the feature is found to pose risks to public safety or national security.

The review comes at a time when cyber fraud has been rising across India. Investigators have repeatedly identified WhatsApp as a platform used to initiate scams ranging from fake investment schemes and digital arrest frauds to phishing campaigns and impersonation attempts. Authorities are assessing whether allowing people to communicate through usernames instead of phone numbers could create additional challenges in tracing offenders while balancing user privacy.

WhatsApp plans to introduce usernames globally later this year as one of its biggest privacy updates in recent years. The optional feature will allow users to create a unique username instead of sharing their phone number while starting new conversations. Users who choose not to use usernames can continue communicating through their phone numbers.

Usernames will be unique, can contain up to 35 characters and may be changed or removed by users at any time. The feature is intended to improve privacy, particularly when interacting with businesses, creators or people users do not know personally. Meta also plans to let creators, businesses and organisations reserve usernames matching their Instagram and Facebook identities through the company’s Accounts Centre.

In a statement issued on Wednesday, WhatsApp defended the feature and said it includes multiple safeguards to reduce abuse and impersonation. A company spokesperson said the username system is not yet live and will be introduced gradually later this year.

“To protect against impersonation, we’ve held the highest-profile names, think public figures, government entities, celebrities, verified Meta accounts, so they can only ever be claimed by their legitimate owners and lookalike derivatives of known names are held as well,” the spokesperson said.

WhatsApp said users will still need a phone number to use the service and that other people must know a user’s exact username before they can send a message. The platform said it will limit how many people an account can contact, block repeated attempts to guess usernames and use systems to detect and remove activity associated with impersonation and other abusive behaviour.

The company added that when someone sends a message through a username for the first time, users will be informed whether the sender is using a new account, is already a contact, shares a mutual group or is based in another country, allowing them to decide whether to respond.

India remains WhatsApp’s largest market, with more than 500 million users.

The proposed feature has also attracted criticism from cybersecurity experts and startup founders. Paytm founder and Chief Executive Vijay Shekhar Sharma said on X that similar sounding usernames could become a fresh avenue for impersonation and scams. Jasveer Singh, co-founder and Chief Executive of

KnotDating, also questioned how WhatsApp would maintain accountability while offering greater privacy through usernames.

House committee may

effect on the 31st day. The action could either be ordered by the president or governor on the advice of the prime minister or chief minister, respectively, or happen automatically under the provisions of the Bill.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah introduced the Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill in August last year. Following protests from opposition parties, it was referred to a 31-member Joint Parliamentary Committee headed by BJP MP Aparajita Sarangi for detailed examination.

The committee has held 10 rounds of meetings since December 2025. According to sources, a draft report is expected to be circulated by July 10, with the panel scheduled to meet on July 17 to finalise and adopt its recommendations before Parliament convenes.

Sources said the committee is likely to recommend retaining most of the Bill’s provisions, including the clause on automatic removal after 30 days of detention. However, it may also suggest safeguards to reduce the possibility of political misuse. These are expected to include limiting the law’s application to serious offences and introducing thresholds regarding the nature of crimes covered under the legislation.

Members of the ruling alliance are understood to have rejected the opposition’s argument that the proposal is undemocratic, anti-federal, and contrary to the principles of natural justice because it permits removal based on custody rather than conviction. According to sources, several committee members believe that a period of 30 days gives an accused sufficient opportunity to seek bail, with treasury bench members arguing that bail can be sought at least three times during that period.

The proposal has drawn strong criticism from opposition parties, which have argued that it could be misused through central investigative agencies to target non-BJP governments and destabilise elected state administrations. They have cited the cases of former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal and Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren, both of whom spent more than 100 days in jail after being arrested in separate alleged corruption cases.

Most members of the INDIA bloc boycotted the committee’s proceedings, maintaining that the ruling alliance’s numerical majority meant their objections would not influence the final outcome. Opposition members who remained on the panel, including AIMIM MP Asaduddin Owaisi and NCP (SP) MP Supriya Sule, are expected to submit notes of dissent when the report is adopted. YSRCP Rajya Sabha MP S. Niranjan Reddy is also a member of the committee.

Adoption of the report by the committee is a routine parliamentary procedure before a Bill is presented in Parliament for consideration and passage during the upcoming session.

Heavy rains

two houses, causing major structural damage and cracks in walls. The SEOC said 35 roads were shut across the state, including 18 in Kullu and

11 in Mandi, while 127 electricity transformers were affected. Schools reopened after closing during the heatwave, but attendance remained low because of the weather.

In Karnataka, three members of a family, including two girls, were killed after a rain-triggered landslide destroyed their house in the Nagori area of Mangaluru early Wednesday. Three others were rescued. Preliminary findings suggested that continuous rainfall loosened the hillside above the house, causing a large mass of soil to collapse onto the structure.

Maharashtra witnessed widespread flooding after heavy rain hit Thane, Palghar and the Mumbai Metropolitan Region. Stormwater drains overflowed, leaving several low-lying neighbourhoods submerged and many residents stranded. In Ulhasnagar, a 70-year-old woman trapped inside her flooded home in the Jijamata locality was rescued by fire brigade personnel after remaining stranded for hours. Videos showing rescuers carrying her through knee-deep water circulated widely on social media.

Authorities issued a red alert for Palghar, warning of extremely heavy rainfall over the next 24 hours. Schools and colleges in the district will remain closed on Thursday. An orange alert has also been issued for Mumbai, while Thane is expected to receive very heavy rainfall over the next three days. In Navi Mumbai’s Nerul, two girls survived an electric shock after coming into contact with an exposed live wire on a water-logged road.

Elsewhere, lightning killed two people and injured eight others, including four children, in Uttar Pradesh.

In Jammu and Kashmir, pilgrimages to the Machail Mata and Mindhal Mata shrines in Kishtwar district remained suspended because of continuous rain, slippery roads and the threat of shooting storms.

Flood-hit Arunachal Pradesh continued to deal with the aftermath of flash floods and landslides. Union ministers Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Kiren Rijiju assured the state of the Centre’s support for relief, rehabilitation and long-term flood mitigation. Over the past seven days, the disaster has claimed four lives, injured 21 people and left two missing while causing extensive damage to homes, roads, bridges and other public infrastructure.

The IMD said a low-pressure area is likely to form over the northwest Bay of Bengal on July 3. Supported by favourable wind patterns and moisture from the Bay, heavy to very heavy rainfall is expected across several districts of south Bengal between July 4 and 7.

Rain also brought relief from intense heat in Punjab, Haryana and Chandigarh, where showers were reported in several cities. In Uttarakhand, where the southwest monsoon has covered most parts of the state, an orange alert has been issued for heavy to very heavy rain in Dehradun and Bageshwar districts. The IMD also said the monsoon is expected to reach Delhi within the next two days, bringing an end to the season’s lingering summer heat.

Vikram Misri

Career diplomat Misri, a 1989-batch Indian Foreign Service officer, was working as the Deputy National Security Adviser (Dy NSA) before his appointment as the foreign secretary.

He has the rare distinction of serving as private secretary to three prime ministers -- Inder Kumar

Gujral, Manmohan Singh and Narendra Modi. Before he was appointed as the deputy NSA, Misri served as India’s ambassador to China from 2019-2021.

Misri is believed to have played a key role in talks between India and China after tensions flared significantly following the Galwan Valley clashes in June, 2020.

He has also served as India’s ambassador to Spain (2014-2016) and Myanmar (2016-2018) besides having stints in many Indian missions including Pakistan, the US, Germany, Belgium and Sri Lanka.

MPOST

Kharge, Nitin Nabin invited

Shehbaz Sharif has said an official delegation will attend.

Iranian authorities said Khamenei, killed in US-Israel strikes on February 28, will be buried at the Imam Reza shrine on July 9 after funeral ceremonies in Tehran, Qom and Mashhad. Organisers have invited people worldwide to attend the Muharram period ceremonies.

AGENCIES

Gymkhana

At the time, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, representing the Union government, had assured the court that any eviction process would be carried out strictly in accordance with the law after issuing due notice.

A senior ministry official said on Wednesday that eviction proceedings have now been initiated in line with the legal process.

According to the notice, the competent authority has concluded that the land is urgently required for strengthening and securing defence infrastructure, public security purposes, urgent institutional needs, governance infrastructure and other projects considered to be in the larger public interest.

The notice states that valuable government land in the national capital cannot continue to remain under unauthorised occupation when it is required for government purposes and public interest.

Quoting the provisions of the Public Premises Act, the estate officer said, “In pursuance of sub-section (1) of section 4 of the Act, I hereby call upon you to show cause on or before July 7 at 2.30 pm why such an order of eviction should not be made.”

The notice also asks the club to appear either in person or through an authorised representative with all evidence supporting its case during the hearing scheduled for July 7 at 2.30 pm.

It further warns, “In case, you fail to appear on the said date and time, the case will be decided ex-parte.”

The Delhi Gymkhana Club occupies a sprawling 27.3 acre property at 2, Safdarjung Road in Lutyens’ Delhi. The land was originally leased to the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd, now known as Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd, for operating a social and sporting club. The premises are located next to the Prime Minister’s residence on Lok Kalyan Marg and lie within a high security administrative zone that also houses several key central government and defence establishments.

LPG prices cut

Commercial LPG prices were

'HAS TAKEN THE WAVE OF INNOVATION TO ALL PARTS OF INDIA'

Digital India has redefined India’s global identity, says PM Modi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday lauded the Digital India initiative of the government, and said it has redefined governance, empowered citizens and accelerated all-round development by touching every aspect of life. Eleven years of Digital India has given India a new identity worldwide, he asserted.

“Today, we mark 11 years since the Digital India initiative was launched. This initiative has redefined governance, empowered citizens and accelerated all-round development. It has touched every aspect of life,” Modi said in a post on X.

The prime minister said from seamless digital payments and direct benefit transfers reaching beneficiaries with transparency to the expanding digital public infrastructure, technology has become a pow-



PM Narendra Modi meets Emaar Properties founder Mohamed Alabbar, in New Delhi, on Wednesday PTI

Highlights

- » Modi said young entrepreneurs, startups and innovators from every corner of the country are creating solutions to the pressing challenges that the planet faces
- » This initiative has strengthened education, healthcare, agriculture, commerce and public service delivery, making governance more transparent, efficient and accessible, he said

erful instrument for furthering 'Ease of Living.'

"Digital India has taken the wave of innovation to all parts of India, especially villages, tier-2 and tier-3 cities," he said.

Modi said young entrepreneurs, startups and innovators from every corner of the country are creating solutions to the pressing challenges that the planet faces.

This initiative has strength-

ened education, healthcare, agriculture, commerce and public service delivery, making governance more transparent, efficient and accessible, he said.

Modi said the government's strides in the digital world have ensured that India is making rapid progress in emerging technologies such as AI, semiconductors, quantum computing and more. "This too will open new avenues for

growth and opportunity. Our focus will remain on creating a future where technology serves humanity, empowers every citizen and drives sustainable development," he said.

Modi said Digital India is the strong foundation of a developed and self-reliant India and over the past 11 years, it has played a crucial role in empowering the poor and deprived while making the lives

of citizens easier. "From the expansion of optical fibre networks to digital transactions, the unprecedented success of this campaign has drawn the attention of the entire world towards India," he said, adding, "When over a billion people embrace technology, the impact is transformative!".

Officials noted that before 2015, public services often meant long queues, paperwork, and limited connectivity but Digital India helped bridge the digital divide by expanding internet access and bringing services online.

The programme also promoted the democratisation of digital technologies through affordable internet and digital access at population scale.

Over the last decade, Digital India has become the foundation of India's digital economy and Digital Public Infrastructure.

Politicians, ex-envoys call for revival of India-Pak dialogue

'Revive bilateral dialogue, restore normal ties'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SRINAGAR: More than 100 prominent citizens, including former Jammu and Kashmir chief ministers Farooq Abdullah and Mehbooba Mufti, from India and Pakistan have urged Prime Ministers Narendra Modi and Shehbaz Sharif to revive bilateral dialogue and restore normal ties.

An open letter, signed by Abdullah, Mufti, former RAW chief AS Dulat, Rajiya Sabha MP Manoj Jha, former diplomat Ashraf Jehangir Qazi, moderate separatist leader Mirwaiz Umar Farooq, former Union minister Mani Shankar Aiyar, former Pakistan foreign minister Khurshid Mahmud Kasuri, besides several retired diplomats and civil society members, asked the two governments to take "meaningful and sustained steps towards restoring peace, normalcy, dialogue and cooperation in South Asia".

The letter dated June 30,

The appeal also sought reopening of trade channels, restoration of normal commercial relations

coordinated by OP Shah, chairman of the Centre for Peace and Progress, and signed by 61 Indians and 55 Pakistanis, stressed that "sustained engagement and dialogue remain the only viable path to resolving differences".

The signatories called for the restoration of full diplomatic relations, reinstatement of high commissioners, resumption of normal visa services and reopening of a comprehensive bilateral dialogue on all outstanding issues.

They also sought discussions on Jammu and Kashmir, including revisiting the framework negotiated between 2004 and 2007, along with steps

towards demilitarisation and de-escalation while addressing the "legitimate security concerns" of both countries.

The appeal also sought reopening of trade channels, restoration of normal commercial relations, revival of the Most Favoured Nation or equivalent non-discriminatory trade arrangement and reopening of the Attari-Wagah land border.

It also called for resumption of the Delhi-Lahore bus service, Srinagar-Muzaffarabad bus service, Samjhauta Express and Thar Express, opening of the Kargil-Skardu route and reopening of airspace for commercial flights.

It sought the reopening of the Kartarpur Sahib Corridor, opening of Sharada Peeth for pilgrims, easing travel restrictions, greater exchanges among students, journalists, artists and business persons, and lifting restrictions on media outlets and digital platforms.

SIT gets 15 more days in Ram Mandir donation theft probe

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Mandir has been given an additional 15 days to complete its investigation. The panel will now submit its report to the Uttar Pradesh government on July 15.

The SIT has already submitted a preliminary report and eight accused in the case have been arrested and sent to judicial custody. Investigators have been continuously questioning the accused to uncover the extent of the alleged embezzlement and trace the money trail.

Sources said the probe has so far revealed that the accused

Trust chairman hospitalised

LUCKNOW: Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, chairman of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, has been admitted to the intensive care unit of a private hospital here after being diagnosed with urinary tract infection. A medical bulletin issued by Medanta Hospital here on Wednesday said 89-year-old Das was brought to its emergency department at around 1.30 pm on June 29 in an unconscious condition. After a preliminary examination, doctors said he had a urinary tract infection. AGENCIES

allegedly siphoned off temple donations on several occasions and not in a single incident. The investigators suspect that the stolen money was invested in different places.

The SIT is examining bank accounts, property records and other financial documents linked to the accused and their

family members to determine how the allegedly stolen money was used. Officials said the extension would allow investigators to scrutinise financial transactions and gather more evidence before submitting the final report. The findings will determine whether more people come under the scanner.

'Dirty' defection politics will haunt BJP: Raj

PUNE/THANE: Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray on Wednesday launched a sharp attack on the BJP, alleging its politics of "engineering defections" was "dirty" and warned the party would eventually face the consequences of precedents it was setting.

Talking to reporters in Pune, Thackeray said politics in Maharashtra and elsewhere in the country had been reduced to "money and power", with elections being the central point and defections taking precedence over governance.

The MNS leader, a former BJP ally, rued politics is now revolving largely around money with very little talk of development. "I have been speaking for years about how cities should be built. Development plans are made, but there is no town planning. Cities are not built only with flats, roads and bridges. Builders keep getting plots, money flows

Sena (UBT)'s Ahir wins Council deputy chairman post

MUMBAI: Shiv Sena (UBT) MLC Sachin Ahir was elected unopposed to the post of deputy chairman of the Maharashtra legislative council as a candidate of the ruling Mahayuti on Wednesday. Opposition alliance -- Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) -- had fielded Jagannath Abhyankar of the Shiv Sena (UBT) for the post. However, on the appeal of Legislative Affairs Minister Chandrakant Patil, Shiv Sena (UBT) legislator Anil Parab said the Opposition was withdrawing Abhyankar's candidature. AGENCIES



from that, and politics revolves around money," he said.

Targeting the BJP over the alleged poaching of legislators and MPs from Opposition parties,

Ruling TVK alleges 'horse-trading' bid by DMK; three arrested

CHENNAI: TVK leader and Tamil Nadu Minister R. Nirmal Kumar on Wednesday alleged that the DMK leadership was attempting to engineer defections by offering huge sums of money to his party's MLAs, claiming three persons had been arrested in connection with the alleged "horse-trading" bid.

Kumar said the arrests were made following a complaint by TVK MLA N. Ilayaraja from Uthangarai in Krishnagiri district. According to the police, the legislator was allegedly offered Rs 35 crore in exchange for his "cooperation" on an Assembly resolution against the Speaker.

The MLA rejected the offer and was allegedly threatened

from that, and politics revolves around money," he said.

Targeting the BJP over the alleged poaching of legislators and MPs from Opposition parties,

instructions of Senthil Balaji and Ashok Kumar.

Kumar claimed that for the past 40 days, his party had been alleging that Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and current TVK MLAs with inducements ranging from Rs 10 crore to Rs 50 crore.

The minister alleged that Naresh maintained close contact with Senthil Balaji and Ashok Kumar, identifying legislators to be targeted and coordinating the alleged offers. MP05T

'People like Senthilbalaji offered inducements'

with serious consequences for himself and his family if he disclosed the conversation. Based on his complaint, police registered a case and arrested Thirunavukkarasu, Naresh and Thiagarajan.

A police release said investigations revealed that Naresh was in contact with V. Ashok Kumar, younger brother of former DMK minister and current Coimbatore South MLA V. Senthil Balaji. It further alleged that Thirunavukkarasu approached the MLA on the

Bihar govt to levy 'user fee' on state highways

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PATNA: The Bihar government has decided to levy "user fees" on state highways, a move aimed at ensuring the development and maintenance of roads, officials said on Wednesday.

The decision was taken at a cabinet meeting here chaired by Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary.

"The Bihar Cabinet has approved the proposal to collect user fees on state-owned road assets. The decision aims to ensure the development, upgradation and maintenance of roads across the state," a senior official said.

The cabinet cleared the Road User Fee (Determination and Collection of Rates) Rules, 2026, paving the way for levying the charges.

According to the proposal by the Road Construction Department, Bihar has witnessed rapid development of roads, major bridges, bypasses and other related infrastructure in recent years, which have significantly improved ease of travel, safety and travel time.

"The user fee will help ensure better maintenance of these assets and support the development of a high-quality road network in future. The rules prescribe clear user fee rates for different vehicle categories and provide for an annual revision.

"Additionally, provisions have been made for exemptions for specified user categories, as well as concessional passes and frequent-user discounts for eligible users," the proposal stated.

The rules also provide for higher user charges for non-FASTag vehicles, and include provisions relating to overloaded vehicles. Besides, the cabinet approved allotting government land for establishing five new Kendriya Vidyalayas (central schools) in the state. A proposal to allot five acres of government land for each of the five new schools was cleared.

'Final promise fulfilled': Punjab rolls out financial assistance scheme for women

DHURI: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday rolled out his government's monthly financial assistance scheme for women - "Mawan Dhiyan Satkar Yojna", stating that AAP fulfilled its final poll "guarantee" made ahead of the 2022 Assembly elections.

Under the scheme, women from the general category will receive Rs 1,000 per month, while those belonging to the Scheduled Castes will receive Rs 1,500. Addressing a gathering of women, Mann described the day as "historic" and said the state government rolled out this "landmark" initiative under which more than 40 lakh women have already been registered.

"The 'Satkar Raashi' has

started from July and it will pave the way for women empowerment. This is an ambitious scheme and we have launched it with complete planning to ensure that it continues permanently," he said. Some women at the gathering said they received messages about money being credited to their bank accounts. Mann said beneficiaries above the age of 18 would receive messages regarding the financial assistance.

"The funds will be directly transferred to bank accounts and women who are already receiving social security pensions will also be eligible under the scheme. Around 97 per cent of women in Punjab are expected to benefit and the state government has earmarked Rs 9,300 crore in the

budget for this purpose," he said. Taking on the rival parties, Mann slammed the opposition for "always targeting" his government over this scheme and said now their mouths will be shut following the implementation of 'Mawan Dhiyan Satkar Yojna'.

Mann said although the financial assistance may not make women rich, it would certainly provide them with dignity and self-respect.

"Women deserve the highest respect because they are the source of life itself. The blessings of our mothers and sisters can help us overcome every challenge. Strengthening women's financial autonomy is essential for improving household welfare, promoting gender equity." MP05T

Parliamentary panel members call for statutory status for NTA

Seeks legal framework to bolster NTA's functioning and autonomy

NEW DELHI: Members of a parliamentary panel on Wednesday sought statutory status for the National Testing Agency (NTA) even as they lauded the successful conduct of the NEET-UG re-exam.

The panel members, however, expressed concern over the computer-based test (CBT) mode for the NEET-UG exam from next year and called for taking the interests of the marginalised sections into account.

Former ISRO chairman R Radhakrishnan, who is also the chairman of the high-powered committee set up by the government to suggest reforms in the examination system, appeared before the Parliamentary Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports and discussed steps taken for the NEET re-exam.

NTA Director General Abhishek Singh and Secretary, Ministry of Higher Education Vineet Joshi also appeared before the panel and discussed the lessons learnt from the NEET re-exam held on June 21.

The officials were called by

Key Points

- » The panel members, however, expressed concern over the computer-based test (CBT) mode for the NEET-UG exam from next year and called for taking the interests of the marginalised sections into account
- » Former ISRO chairman

R Radhakrishnan, who is also the chairman of the high-powered committee set up by the government to suggest reforms in the examination system, appeared before the Parliamentary Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports and discussed steps taken for the NEET re-exam.

members asked the officials how the NTA will conduct the examination of this scale on its own next year, as the re-exam was successfully held only after the entire government came into action. From the prime minister to the junior-most official, all were involved in its conduct, they noted.

The sources said the MPs suggested giving more powers to the NTA for independently handling an exam of this magnitude and suggested giving statutory status to the agency.

The Ministry of Educa-

tion established the NTA as an independent, autonomous, and self-sustained premier testing organisation under the Societies Registration Act (1860).

The panel members also expressed concern over several examinees being left out as they arrived late at the exam centres. They also urged the NTA to take steps to help them, saying the visuals of the distraught aspirants being left outside the centre for arriving late were disturbing.

With the NTA now deciding to hold the NEET exam in a computer-based testing format, the members said the interests of marginalised sections should be kept in mind as some may not have access to computers.

Earlier, top officials told the committee about the successful conduct of the NEET re-exam on June 21 and listed several steps being taken. The Committee congratulated them for their efforts. Some MPs also asked why separate tests for nursing and other exams are not held to reduce the number of examinees. AGENCIES

Nation Briefs

YOU WANT TO CRUSH BJP, BUT NATION HAS CRUSH ON BJP: PARTY TO REVANTH REDDY

NEW DELHI: The BJP on Wednesday slammed Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy for mocking its national president Nitin Nabin, asserting that the Congress leader's sycophancy and arrogance will meet its downfall with the defeat of his party in the upcoming polls in the state. On Tuesday, Reddy dismissed Nabin's call to party cadres to work for the BJP's victory in the 2028 Telangana elections, saying it took 15 years for the saffron party to win the Assembly polls in West Bengal, and it would meet the same fate in Telangana. "Recently, a guy came here, Nabin or whatever, I don't really know his name. But he comes here and says the next government is theirs," the chief minister said at an event in Hyderabad. "You said the same thing about West Bengal. It took you 15 years (to form a government) in Bengal. Your tricks might have worked there because Mamata Banerjee was at the helm. But here, all our guys are ready, and they will crush you, Reddy said.

SENIOR RSS PRACHARAKS TO ASSEMBLE IN KARNATAKA FOR ANNUAL MEET

NEW DELHI: Senior RSS pracharaks from across the country will assemble in Karnataka's Belagavi next week to participate in their annual meeting which will discuss a range of issues, including the ongoing nationwide Census exercise. The three-day meeting, which will start on July 10 and conclude on July 12, will also review the work of RSS shakhas and discuss plans for increasing their number to further expand its reach.

Cabinet clears Rs 14,115-crore road projects in Delhi and UP

The 8.1-kilometre project will be developed with total capital cost of Rs 6,969.67 cr

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved highway projects in Delhi and Uttar Pradesh entailing total investment of Rs 14,115 crore.

The construction of a six-lane road tunnel for NH-148AE, connecting Dwarka Expressway with Nelson Mandela Marg, Vasant Kunj in Delhi, has been approved, and the project is expected to be completed in five years, Information and Broadcasting minister Ashwini Vaishnaw told reporters here.

The 8.1-kilometre project will be developed with a total capital cost of Rs 6,969.67 crore.

Besides, the Cabinet, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, gave its nod for the construction of the 117.7-km 4/6-lane access-controlled Kanpur-Kabrai section of NH-34 in Uttar Pradesh.

The estimated cost of the project is Rs 7,145.14 crore.

According to an official statement, the 6-lane tunnel project connecting Dwarka Expressway with Nelson Mandela Marg, Vasant Kunj will provide faster connectivity between West and South Delhi, connecting UER 2/Dwarka Expressway to Vasant Kunj in



Union Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw addresses a press conference after the Union Cabinet meeting, in New Delhi, Wednesday

South Delhi.

It will ease traffic from Gurugram, Dwarka, IGI Airport, and West Delhi towards South Delhi, according to an official statement.

A 1.98-km section of the tunnel will pass beneath the Southern Ridge Forest.

The statement said that the underground twin-tube tunnel minimises surface disruption, preserving the ridge.

The National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) is also proposing an elevated corridor between AIIMS and Mahipalpur. This link will connect the tunnel to the Barapullah elevated road, thereby connecting West Delhi, South Delhi with East Delhi, Ghaziabad and Noida, it added.

According to a separate official statement, the construction of a 4/6-lane access-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The construction of a six-lane road tunnel for NH-148AE, connecting Dwarka Expressway with Nelson Mandela Marg, Vasant Kunj in Delhi, has been approved
- » The statement said that the underground twin-tube tunnel minimises surface disruption, preserving the ridge

controlled greenfield highway project on the Kanpur-Kabrai section of NH-34 will form a key segment of the Bhopal-Kanpur Economic Corridor under the National Highways (O) Programme.

The project will provide seamless, high-speed connectivity between Kanpur and Kabrai, while strengthening onward connectivity to Sagar, Bhopal and other parts of Madhya Pradesh, thereby creating a modern access-controlled economic corridor linking the industrial and commercial centres of Uttar Pradesh with mineral-rich, manufacturing and agricultural regions of Madhya Pradesh, it added.

New Army Chief General Seth unveils ‘VIJAY’ roadmap

Pledges technology-driven and self-reliant force

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Assuming the responsibility of being the 31st Chief of the Army Staff, General Dhiraj Seth, on Wednesday, laid out an ambitious plan to transform the Indian Army, announcing ‘VIJAY’ as the conceptual foundation of his term while reiterating the army’s commitment towards operational readiness, self-reliance, and security.

“We aim at creating a technology-enabled, future-ready Army which is enabled in all respects and can operate effectively in various domains,” he said. Inspired by the Ministry of Defence’s ‘Decade of Transformation’ programme, the Army Chief launched the ‘VIJAY’ acronym, which defined his priorities.

Talking about the first one - Vigilance denoted by ‘V’ - the Army Chief said that the Army would remain vigilant along its frontiers and against the emerging threats while maintaining high operational preparedness.

In relation to ‘I’ for Innovation and Transformation, the Army Chief stated that innovations both in military doctrine and technological solutions would be an integral part of the thinking of the Army as well as its work culture and capabilities



development.

“I will make efforts towards innovations both in doctrine and technological solutions. There will be transformations needed to be able to match with the changing nature of warfare,” he said.

About ‘J’ for Jointness and Integration, the Army Chief stressed the need for greater operational synergy with the Indian Air Force and Indian Navy. It was stressed that national security goes beyond military power and needs Military Civil Fusion as well as Whole-of-Nation Approach.

“This approach not only will ensure the security of the country, but also help us in nation building and Viksit Bharat 2047,” he said.

Commenting on ‘A’ for Atmanirbharata, the Army Chief re-emphasised the importance of indigenous

capabilities development.

“The overall objective is going to be ‘To Win Our Wars With Indigenous Solutions,’” he said, underlining the significance of developing home-grown technologies and being self-sufficient.

On the letter ‘Y’ standing for ‘Yodha First,’ the Army Chief stressed the significance of each individual serving in the Armed Forces - from an Agniveer to the senior-most veteran - is a ‘Yodha.’

“Our soldiers are our greatest asset in the Indian Army. Improving their technical abilities and making them more proficient at what they do will be one of the topmost concerns,” he said, adding the wellbeing, empowerment and professional development of veterans and Veer Naris will continue to be a primary concern for him.

DEMOGRAPHIC CHANGES

High-Level Committee briefs Amit Shah on assessment plan



NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The High-Level Committee on Demographic Changes on Wednesday met Union Home minister Amit Shah at his residence in New Delhi and briefed him on its roadmap to assess demographic changes across the country arising from illegal immigration and other abnormal factors.

The Committee members said during the courtesy meet that they would visit various States and Union Territories to interact with State and Union Territory Governments to seek their inputs and feedback on matters relating to demographic changes.

They also plan to interact with various ministries of the Government of India concerned to take their views on the record on this matter.

In this regard, a questionnaire will also be sent to all the

States and Union Territories by the committee for their views and feedback in advance so that the discussions with the State and UT Administrations could be more detailed and effective.

Home minister complimented the committee for the approach and said that he will ensure that necessary support is provided to the committee for its functioning and during its visit to various states and Union Territories.

He also urged the committee to give its recommendations at the earliest.

The High-Level Committee on Demographic Changes was formed by the Government of India, following up on the Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s announcement made on the occasion of Independence Day celebrations on 15th August 2025, for constituting a “High Powered Demography Mission”.

Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit takes charge as new Vice Chief of IAF

NEW DELHI: Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, who served as the Chief of Integrated Defence Staff during Operation Sindoor, took charge as the new Vice Chief of the Air Staff on Wednesday, officials said.

He succeeded Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor, who superannuated on June 30 after four decades of service in the Indian Air Force (IAF).

Air Marshal Dixit was accorded a guard of honour at

the Vayu Bhawan - the headquarters of the IAF - as he took charge as the new Vice Chief of the Air Staff (VCAS).

Prior to the ceremony, the air officer visited the National War Memorial and laid a wreath to pay homage to the fallen heroes of the armed forces.

Before being appointed as VCAS, he was serving as the Chief of Integrated Defence Staff (CISC) at the Headquar-



Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit assumes charge as the Vice Chief of the Air Staff (VCAS), in New Delhi, Wednesday

ters Integrated Defence Staff (HQ IDS) here.

Air Marshal Dixit assumed the appointment of CISC on May 1, 2025, which he relinquished on June 30.

The HQ IDS said in an X post on Tuesday, “His tenure at HQ IDS was defined by landmark contributions that reshaped the contours of integrated defence playing a pivotal role in Operation Sindoor, a defining moment in India’s national security calculus; steering the release of

20 joint doctrines and primers that institutionalised tri services thought; conceptualising Ran Samwad 2025 and 2026, an unprecedented military dialogue platform; orchestrating the combined and joint commanders conferences 2025 and 2026; and anchoring the formulation of the Defence Forces Vision 2047 - a transformative roadmap for a technology-driven, integrated and future-ready military.”

MPOST

Punjab govt rolls out ‘Mukh Mantri Maavan Dheeyan Satkar Yojna’

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab government rolled out the Mukh Mantri Maavan Dheeyan Satkar Yojna, fulfilling its final election guarantee made ahead of the 2022 Punjab Assembly elections.

Launching the scheme through a dedicated web portal in Dhuri, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann announced the direct transfer of three months’ Satkar Raashi into the bank accounts of eligible beneficiaries, with every woman receiving Rs 3,000 and women from the Scheduled Caste category receiving Rs 4,500.

The payments began reaching beneficiaries during the event itself, with women receiving SMS confirmations on their mobile phones.

CM Mann announced direct transfer of three months’ ‘Satkar Raashi’ into bank accounts of eligible beneficiaries

Sharing a few snippets from this programme, CM Bhagwant Singh Mann stated on X: “Today, the historic launch of the Maavan Dheeyan Satkar Yojna was held in Dhuri. Under the scheme, every woman will receive a ‘Satkar Raashi’ of Rs 1,000 per month, while women from the Scheduled Caste community will receive Rs 1,500 per month. With the rollout of the

scheme, a consolidated amount of Rs 4,500, covering the months of July, August, and September, has been transferred directly into the bank accounts of eligible beneficiaries. Women began receiving SMS confirmations of the transfers during the event itself.”

“Our govt has launched this scheme with meticulous planning to ensure that it continues uninterrupted in the years ahead. This financial assistance will provide significant support to economically weaker families while also serving as a mark of respect for our mothers and daughters,” the post concluded.

Addressing the gathering after launching the scheme, CM Mann, amid a huge round of applause, described the day as historic.

Himachal: Eight traditional products registered as GIs

Major boost to branding, legal protection of indigenous products

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: In a major boost to the branding and legal protection of indigenous products, eight traditional products of Himachal Pradesh, valued for their cultural, agricultural and economic significance, have been granted Geographical Indication (GI) registration.

The newly registered GIs are Seabuckthorn (Chharma) of Spiti, Salooni Safed Makka, Chamba Metal Art, Sirmauri Loiya, Kinnauri Topi, Sepuvadi of Mandi, Kinnauri apple and Kinnauri jewellery.

Himachal Pradesh has secured 17 traditional products with the Geographical Indication registration through HIMCOSTE. These products represent the rich heritage, traditional knowledge, craftsmanship, and agricultural excellence of different regions of the state and reflect the state’s unique identity.

Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu expressed happiness at the landmark achievement of registering these

KEY POINTS

- » The newly registered GIs are Seabuckthorn (Chharma) of Spiti, Salooni Safed Makka, Chamba Metal Art, Sirmauri Loiya, Kinnauri Topi, Sepuvadi of Mandi, Kinnauri apple and Kinnauri jewellery
- » CM Sukhu expressed happiness at the landmark achievement

traditional products under GIs.

“This achievement was a testimony to the sustained efforts of the state government during the last three and a half years to preserve, protect and promote Himachal Pradesh’s traditional heritage,” said Chief Minister.

He hoped that the recognition would safeguard the authenticity of these products and ensure their market value, besides creating new livelihood opportunities and strengthening the rural economy.

Sukhu said, “This recognition will help to preserve our invaluable cultural heritage while opening new avenues for economic growth, rural entrepreneurship, and sustainable livelihood. I congratulate the people of the state on this remarkable accomplishment.”

The Chief Minister reminded that the state government was actively pursuing Geographical Indication registration for four additional indigenous products, viz. Bhot Jau (Barley from the Pangri region of Chamba), Chamba Chukh, Plectranthus honey (from Bharmour region of Chamba), and Sirmaur Ginger. He directed the concerned authorities to vigorously take up this matter for GI registration.

He said that the recognition would strengthen the livelihoods of indigenous communities, artisans, weavers, farmers and traditional producers by creating greater opportunities for value addition, rural entrepreneurship, and sustainable economic development.

CBI arrests Haryana cadre IPS officer in bribery case

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested a 2012-batch Haryana cadre Indian Police Service (IPS) officer, Deepak Gahlawat, in a bribery case related to the probe into the sale of counterfeit drugs in Pudukcherry.

The CBI has arrested Deepak Gahlawat, currently posted in the central deputation of Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) in New Delhi, in connection with a case registered against him for allegedly demanding illicit gratification from private entities, citing the utilisation of his personal influence in cases under the CBI jurisdiction.

The case was filed on June 8, 2026, against Pradeep Singh, an Inspector in Delhi Police, and two private complainants. However, the CBI during the course of the investigation discovered some linkages with the alleged involvement of an IPS officer.

As per the latest development, the CBI had arrested Inspector Pradeep Singh in a trap laid for him along with six private individuals. The agency has also recovered about Rs 25 lakh as trap money and simultaneously, an additional sum of Rs 90 lakh in cash apart from several incriminating documents.

Moreover, a series of searches have been conducted at various places in connection with the case, and several digital devices and hard disks along with official records and other relevant documents have been recovered.

The CBI stated that the searches were conducted to gather documentary and electronic evidence related to the alleged illegal gratification receipt for imparting undue influence.

It may be mentioned that the CBI is investigating the matter to reveal the extent of the alleged conspiracy and the modus operandi adopted, in addition to tracing the flow of money.

Submit tender terms & conditions for approval in 15 days: Saini to Health Dept

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday directed officials of the Health Department to ensure the early installation of an advanced PET scan machine at the Ambala Cancer Hospital for the convenience of cancer patients.

He instructed the officials to prepare the tender terms and conditions within the next 15 days and submit them for approval. Transport minister Anil Vij and Chief Principal Secretary to the Chief Minister, Rajesh Khullar were also present on the occasion.

Saini said that the Ambala Cancer Hospital is an important healthcare institution for cancer patients, and the avail-

ability of a PET scan machine is essential for providing better treatment facilities.

He said that a PET scan machine is an advanced medical imaging system that plays a crucial role in detecting cancer in the human body. It also helps determine the stage of cancer and whether it has spread to other parts of the body. The machine can also assess the effectiveness of chemotherapy and radiotherapy, thereby significantly supporting the treatment process.

The Chief Minister directed that instead of the previously proposed analogue machine, a digital PET scan machine should be installed at the Ambala Cancer Hospital to ensure more accurate diagnostic results and better treatment

outcomes.

He also emphasised that affordable rates should be fixed for cancer patients undergoing PET scan tests so that the financial burden on patients is minimised. He added that although eligible beneficiaries under the Ayushman Bharat Scheme can avail PET scan services free of cost at any empanelled hospital, the facility at Ambala Cancer Hospital would be made available on a priority basis.

Meanwhile, CM Saini on Wednesday directed officers to ensure that the Haryana Teacher Eligibility Test (HTET), being conducted by the Board of School Education Haryana (BSEH), is held in a transparent, fair, and efficient manner, similar to the Common Eligibility Test (CET).

Nation Briefs

GLOBAL BUSINESS CONVERGENCE SUMMIT STRENGTHENS GLOBAL TRADE PARTNERSHIPS

NEW DELHI: The Global Business Convergence Summit 2026 organised by World Association for Small and Medium Enterprises (WASME) concluded in New Delhi after gathering over 45 companies and 31 nations’ diplomats to promote trade, investment and international business cooperation. The summit hosted Government-to-Business (G2B) session on AI-based business solutions, technology, governance and sustainable development. WASME Executive Secretary Sanjeev Layak said that the summit has facilitated enduring global partnerships for MSMEs. In addition, the Senior Advisor at WASME Naveen Sharma emphasized the need for trust and collaboration in international business engagement.

BALCONY OF OLD BUILDING COLLAPSES IN SOUTH MUMBAI, MAN DIES

MUMBAI: A 51-year-old man died after a part of a third-floor balcony of a ‘cessed’ building collapsed in south Mumbai’s Walkeshwar area, civic officials said on Wednesday. The incident occurred at the four-storey Surya Prakash building on Babulnath Road at around 11.22 pm on Tuesday as rains lashed the city. It was a cessed building, a civic official said. Cessed buildings are old private structures that pay a ‘cess’ to the Maharashtra Housing and Area Development Authority for maintenance. Santosh Ramchandra Bharaskar, who was injured in the incident, was rushed to the state-run JJ Hospital where doctors declared him “brought dead”, the official said.



EDITORIAL
DIGITAL
DECEPTION?

Privacy has become one of the defining demands of the digital age. As online communication expands into every aspect of modern life—from banking and commerce to healthcare and governance—people increasingly seek ways to protect their personal information. Against this backdrop, WhatsApp’s proposed introduction of usernames, allowing users to communicate without revealing their phone numbers, appears to be a welcome privacy enhancement. At first glance, the feature addresses a genuine concern. It promises greater control over personal information, especially in group chats, marketplaces, professional networking and interactions with strangers. Yet the same innovation also opens a far more complex question: what happens when privacy comes at the cost of trust? In a country where digital fraud has reached alarming proportions, replacing a relatively verifiable phone number with a platform-managed username could fundamentally alter the security architecture that millions of Indians have unconsciously relied upon for years. Technology has repeatedly demonstrated that every new convenience creates a new vulnerability, and history suggests that cybercriminals are often quicker to exploit innovation than institutions are to regulate it.

India’s digital economy presents a particularly challenging environment for such a transition. The country has more than 500 million WhatsApp users, making it the platform’s largest market globally. Simultaneously, India has witnessed an unprecedented explosion in cyber-enabled financial crime. According to official data, citizens lost thousands of crores of rupees to online fraud in the past year alone, with messaging platforms increasingly serving as the first point of contact for scammers. Criminals today impersonate bank officials, police officers, tax authorities, courier companies, employers and even relatives using stolen photographs and carefully crafted messages. Their success depends not merely on technology but on psychology—they exploit familiarity and urgency. Introducing usernames could unintentionally make this deception easier. A phone number, while not foolproof, provides a tangible identifier. Users can call it, save it, compare it with previous conversations or cross-check it through multiple channels. A username, however, can be manipulated with remarkable ease. Minor substitutions, extra letters, punctuation marks or visually similar characters can create convincing imitations that many users, particularly senior citizens or first-time smartphone owners, may fail to distinguish. Experience across other social media platforms shows that verified badges alone do not eliminate impersonation. Fraudsters rarely need perfect imitation; they need only enough resemblance to deceive for a few critical minutes.

The implications extend far beyond individual conversations. Businesses, banks, government departments and customer service channels increasingly use WhatsApp to communicate with citizens. Many consumers have grown accustomed to recognising official communications through known phone numbers or verified business accounts. As usernames become central identifiers, that trust model must evolve. Verification can no longer depend solely on appearance or familiarity. Financial institutions may have to invest in stronger digital authentication, cryptographic verification, secure in-app confirmation systems and greater customer education. Small businesses face an even greater challenge. Unlike multinational corporations that can afford sophisticated cybersecurity infrastructure, neighbourhood retailers, freelancers and small enterprises could find themselves vulnerable to copycat usernames that divert customers, payments or sensitive information. The problem is not merely technological but economic. Every successful impersonation weakens confidence in digital commerce, and rebuilding public trust is invariably more expensive than preventing its erosion in the first place. Policymakers are therefore justified in examining the legal and regulatory implications before such a feature is rolled out at scale. Digital innovation cannot operate independently of consumer protection, especially when the platform concerned functions as essential communication infrastructure for millions.

None of this implies that usernames should be abandoned. On the contrary, they address legitimate privacy concerns. Users should not be compelled to disclose personal phone numbers to every online seller, housing society, tuition group, delivery executive or professional contact. The feature could substantially reduce unwanted marketing calls, data harvesting and unsolicited messaging. It may also improve safety for journalists, women, activists and professionals who frequently interact with unfamiliar individuals. The challenge lies not in the concept but in its implementation. Usernames should be accompanied by rigorous safeguards that extend beyond basic reservation systems. Platforms must deploy artificial intelligence capable of detecting lookalike identities, proactively suspend suspicious accounts, strengthen reporting mechanisms and ensure that verified identities are highly visible and difficult to counterfeit. Multi-layer authentication, contextual warnings before first contact, secure links between usernames and underlying verified phone numbers, and rapid grievance redressal should become standard features rather than optional enhancements. Regulators, meanwhile, must establish clear accountability for impersonation-related fraud, ensuring that digital platforms bear responsibility for maintaining secure identity ecosystems. Ultimately, privacy and trust should not be treated as competing objectives. Digital platforms succeed only when users believe they are both protected and identifiable. Innovation that strengthens privacy while weakening authenticity risks becoming a gift to cybercriminals rather than consumers. As digital identities increasingly replace physical ones, the central challenge is no longer creating new ways to connect, but ensuring that people can confidently know whom they are connecting with.

NEXUS
OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS
AN AUTHOR AND
A FORMER
CIVIL SERVANT

Across hospital corridors, slum communities, brick kilns, and classrooms, the Foundation is quietly rewriting the meaning of social service

Building a Culture of Compassion

From fighting hunger to empowering communities, the ‘So Am I Foundation’ has built a replicable model of compassionate, community-driven social transformation

On an invitation from an organisation for a conference, I was on a visit to Bhubaneswar for just a day. However, when the So Am I Foundation invited me to attend one of its education and social integration-related programmes, I couldn’t say no despite a tight schedule, as they were the winners of the 2024 Nexus of Good Annual Award. I am glad that I participated in the event. What I saw and learnt there was truly amazing. I also got to know more about the organisation and the wonderful work it was doing in the true spirit of Nexus of Good.

Founded in 2019, the So Am I Foundation (SAI Foundation) is a humanitarian non-profit organisation dedicated to fighting hunger, deprivation, and social exclusion. Operating under a core philosophy that service is a constant and universal human duty (dharma), the foundation focuses on a holistic vision: “Hunger-Free Odisha,” delivered with dignity, love, and compassion. Over its six years of impactful service, the foundation has expanded its scope from immediate nutritional relief to long-term empowerment, self-reliance, and youth engagement.

The foundation is engaged in a number of activities.

Healthcare & Nutritional Support (SAIRAM Program)

Hospital Feeding Initiatives: Recognising that patient attendants and vulnerable families face steep challenges in securing daily food during medical emergencies, SAI launched ‘SAIRAM’ (So Am I Rendering Assistance at Medicals).

AIIMS Bhubaneswar: The foundation has maintained a silent, uninterrupted presence outside AIIMS Bhubaneswar for over 1,300 consecutive days, serving nearly 500 hot, nutritious meals daily to patients, caregivers, and recovering individuals.

SCB Medical College, Cuttack: A similar daily lifeline operates here, providing



The So Am I Foundation has transformed everyday compassion into a scalable model of community-led development

nourishment to 250 individuals every single day.

To date, the foundation has successfully delivered over 600,000 nourishing meals across these hospital corridors. **Skill-Building & Self-Reliance (SWA-AAHAAR)** Moving beyond basic sustenance, the foundation actively invests in structural, long-term change.

Slum Community Empowerment (Basti Ku Chala): In collaboration with the Commissionerate of Police (Bhubaneswar-Cuttack), SAI launched training programmes for marginalised youth and women living in slum areas.

Around 800 young men and women have been upskilled in vocational domains, including professional cooking (under the Swa-Aahar initiative), Mehendi art, and beauty and wellness, enabling independent household income generation.

Project DREAMS: Launched in 2022, this initiative focuses on De-addiction, Reformation, and Entrepreneurial Assistance. Through integration with SAI’s Garam Garam food vending programme, former substance abusers are provided with a second chance at life. The foundation equips them with customised vending carts, tools, and starter kits to build a dignified livelihood.

Resource Optimisation and Community Safety Nets

Odisha’s First Food Bank (Arna Hin Brahma): Established at the foundation’s inception in 2019, this innovative system recovers high-quality surplus food from hotels, weddings, and events, redirecting it safely to the hungry instead of letting it go to waste.

The Cloth Bank: Operating as a sustainable citywide reuse movement, this initiative handles donations of gently used garments from citizens alongside brand-new contributions from wholesale textile dealers, providing clothing and restoring basic dignity.

Shraddha Arpan: A community-driven participatory scheme in which households voluntarily set aside a handful of dry rations every day. Collected at the end of every month, these contributions are repackaged to support the city’s most destitute families. **Reaching the Forgotten (SAMAVEDNA Program)**

The foundation runs strategic outreach campaigns targeted at groups traditionally left on the margins of urban progress.

Brick Kiln Migrants: SAI distributes winter clothing, blankets, educational learning kits, and toys to the children of migrant labourers working in brick kilns outside Bhubaneswar.

City Scavengers & Sanitation Heroes: To honour those who clean urban streets and are often undervalued, SAI hosts festival distributions (such as during Diwali and Dussehra), sharing new clothes, sweets, and celebratory gift boxes.

Pediatric Cancer Support: Foundation volunteers closely engage with children at pediatric cancer shelter homes, organising recreational activities such as movie screenings and interactive outings to bring joy during intensive medical treatment. **Educational Equity & Value-Based Learning**

Dishantika Workshops: An educational framework developed by SAI to cultivate the concepts of inclusivity, mutual respect, and practical equality among school-aged children.

SAI YUVA (The Youth Wing): A dedicated student and youth division designed to anchor the next generation in social empathy. These young ambassadors independently drive food distribution campaigns, event logistics, and inclusion programmes, ensuring deep integration with the state’s changing social fabric.

Historic Crisis Response: The COVID-19 Pandemic During the strict initial lockdowns and subsequent waves of the pandemic, SAI stepped up

to address the surging, silent emergency of food insecurity.

- Launched a massive community kitchen infrastructure in November 2020.
- Served more than 200,000 freshly cooked hot meals directly to frontline personnel (traffic police and on-duty officers), stranded migrant labourers, elderly citizens left without caregivers, persons with disabilities, and families of admitted COVID-19 patients.
- Distributed extensive 15-day dry ration kits to 7,000 families across regions including Bhubaneswar, Boudh, Puri, Cuttack, and Khorda.
- Extended targeted survival packages to 2,000 underprivileged temple priests (Mandir Pujakas) and 1,000 junior artists from the entertainment ecosystem whose livelihoods had collapsed entirely.

National and Global Expansion

The efficacy of the foundation’s operating model has enabled it to grow well beyond its original regional boundaries.

National Recognition: On December 15, 2024, the foundation received the prestigious Nexus of Good Annual Award in New Delhi for its outstanding, replicable interventions against urban hunger and its exemplary public welfare initiatives in Odisha.

International Footprint (USA Expansion): To take its local community mobilisation model to a global scale, the foundation has officially registered in Virginia, USA, securing 501(c)(3) tax-exempt status.

This chapter focuses on applying community-driven food security networks to tackle food deserts and nutritional disparities within vulnerable communities in the United States.

What the So Am I Foundation has done so far is truly remarkable. The model it has developed can be replicated and scaled in the true spirit of Nexus of Good through public-private partnerships.

Views expressed are personal

QUIET
REFLECTIONS



MITALI MADHUSMITA

THE WRITER IS
A RETIRED IRS
OFFICER WHO
SERVED AS THE
PRINCIPAL CHIEF
COMMISSIONER
OF INCOME TAX IN
ANDHRA PRADESH
AND TELANGANA

While we do have age-defying sportsmen like Rafael Nadal, yogis, and so on, age does catch up with us. Our spirit or mind may be willing, but often our body tells us to slow down

More Than Another Year

Whether marked by cake, candles, seaweed soup, or silent gratitude, birthdays remain one of humanity’s most enduring rituals—celebrating resilience, connection and the promise of another beginning

Ever wondered why it is that we celebrate the day of our birth? This year, as the wishes and calls poured in for what I consider an annual ritual, this thought set me exploring the genesis behind the ritual. Historically speaking, surviving one more year in an essentially ‘survival of the fittest’ scenario might have been considered a genuine achievement, a cause for the celebration of life. In today’s world, surviving wars, the polluted water and air of our cities, viruses like COVID-19, potholed roads, and so on are possibly causes for celebration. A birthday can also function as a temporal anchor that enables us to learn from our past journey and look forward to the future. It is indeed a comforting milestone, helping to distract us from the inevitability of ageing. Above all, it is a social connection, an excuse to share joy and gather family and friends. Delving into ancient traditions, we know that the Egyptians considered the crowning of a Pharaoh as the birth of a god, celebrated with sweet breads, cakes, and *khak* cookies. The ancient Greeks lit candles on moon-shaped honey cakes to honour Artemis. In medieval Germany, a child’s birthday was traditionally celebrated as *Kinderfest*, the candles on a cake symbolising the ‘light of life’.

It is very interesting to know the practices of celebrating birthdays across the globe and the reasons behind them. In Canada, butter or margarine is rubbed on noses; presumably, a slippery nose makes it difficult for bad luck to strike. South Koreans celebrate with a bowl of hearty seaweed soup,



The greatest birthday gift is the opportunity to begin another year with purpose

packed with nutrients, while the Chinese have long, uncut noodles, both practices symbolising longevity. In some European countries, birthday practices almost resemble corporeal punishment. Spaniards and Italians pull the earlobes once for every year of the person’s age, while the British administer the birthday bump. In Mexico, the colourful papier-mâché piñata, filled with sweets, is broken while the birthday person, with hands tied behind the back, tries to take a bite of cake directly from the platter to cries of ‘gordita’. In India, we wear new clothes, visit temples, and seek the blessings of our elders. Millennials have added the cake-cutting practice, while the generation aged 60 and above remembers the disadvantaged on their birthdays.

This is a generalisation; there are many young people who are engaged in social causes all year round and are not confined to birthdays.

Charles Schulz, creator of the *Charlie Brown* and *Peanuts* comic series, is famously reported to have said, “Just remember, once you’re over the hill you begin to pick up speed.” No one represents this description better than good old Uncle Sam’s present leader, with his daily utterances on Truth Social. Jokes apart, do birthdays provide us with an opportunity to reflect on our living experiences? Or are they a sombre occasion, once we cross a certain age, reminding us of our physical and mental diminishment? It is certainly a moment to pause and reflect on how far we have come and wonder how

we can keep ourselves abreast of the changing landscape. Technology is the biggest challenge; it is changing fast, and one must keep pace to remain relevant and connected. I recall, with some degree of embarrassment, the way I resisted the use of a mobile phone or WhatsApp when everyone around me took to them like a duck takes to water.

Birthdays help keep track of time. Often, formal workplaces mandate a certain age at which one can apply for a job or retire. The threshold date may vary based on economic status and other factors, which are subject to debate, but that is a separate matter. It certainly imparts a sense of certainty, both to the employee as well as the organisation. They are also valuable body clocks. While we

do have age-defying sportsmen like Rafael Nadal, yogis, and so on, age does catch up with us. Our spirit or mind may be willing, but often our body tells us to slow down. Our diet, food habits, and exercise need to be tailored around our vitals. We have heard of the legendary longevity of the Japanese. The key lifestyle pillars include the principle of *Hara Hachi Bu* (eating until 80 per cent full), practising *Ikigai* (finding a daily purpose), consuming nutrient-dense foods (such as fermented soy, diverse vegetables, fish, and green tea), and staying naturally active. Their lifestyle saves both consumers and taxpayers millions of dollars every year in medical costs alone.

For me, personally, every birthday is both a celebration of having muddled through life and an expression of gratitude to the world for having stood beside me. As a child, like every other child, it was actually a difficult task waiting for the birthday celebrations to begin as you eagerly anticipated what new dress, special food, and gifts awaited you. Somewhere along the way, and with the passing of years, this excitement dims and becomes less meaningful. It does feel good to know that your near and dear ones remembered an old fossil not because it was merely a ritual for them, but also out of genuine love and fondness for your unique qualities. It is a day for the affirmation of our self-worth, a celebration of our inner child! I have always tried, in turn, to call the birthday person to pay my personal tribute, provided, of course, that I remember the person’s actual date of birth!

Views expressed are personal

INT'L SALES RECORD 'WEAKEST INCREASE' SINCE MARCH 2023

Manufacturing activity moderates in June amid weaker demand: PMI

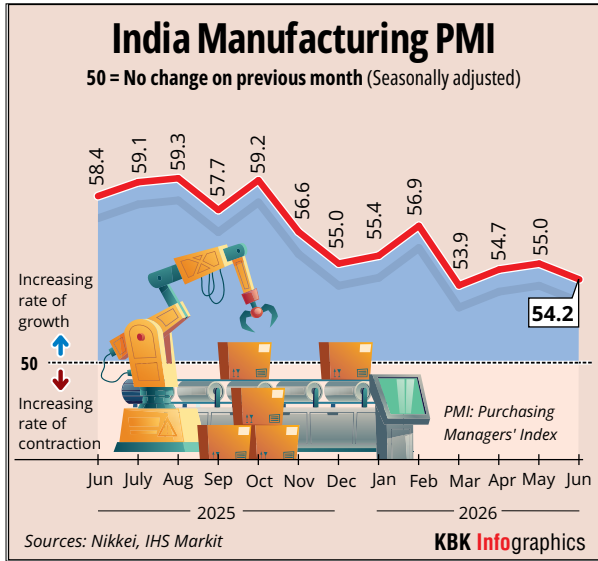
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's manufacturing sector activity growth eased in June, as new business orders and international sales increased at softer rates, resulting in slower expansions in buying levels, employment and output, a monthly survey said on Wednesday.

The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index fell from 55.0 in May to 54.2 in June, pointing to the second-weakest improvement in the health of the sector since mid-2022.

The HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) is a gauge of overall conditions derived from measures of new orders, output, employment, supplier delivery times and stocks of purchases.

In the PMI parlance, a print



above 50 means expansion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction.

As per the survey, several firms reported an improvement in demand conditions, but others

noted subdued client appetite for their products and fierce market competition.

"India's manufacturing PMI eased to 54.2 in June from 55.0 in May, signalling contin-

HIGHLIGHTS

» Manufacturing PMI fell from 55.0 in May to 54.2 in June

» This points to the second-weakest improvement in the health of the sector since mid-2022

ued expansion but at a slower pace. The moderation suggests demand has cooled slightly after the earlier surge linked to the Middle East conflict.

"Growth slowed across output, new orders, export orders and employment, with international sales recording their weakest increase since March 2023," Pranjul Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC, said.

International demand for Indian goods continued to improve in June, but the pace of growth was modest and the weakest in 39 months amid

reports of subdued sales to some European markets.

On the price front, with demand growth fading, goods producers became more reluctant to lift their fees. Output charges rose to a moderate degree that was the least pronounced in three months.

"... Both the input and output price indices declined, pointing to softer inflation pressures as geopolitical disruptions begin receding," Bhandari said.

On the job front, stable workloads and a lack of demand pressure led businesses to pause or scale back hiring. A general absence of capacity pressures restricted recruitment activity at the end of the first fiscal quarter.

"Backlogs of work were broadly unchanged, and employment expanded at the weakest rate in 2026 so far," the survey noted.

GST mop-up grows 14% to about Rs 1.95L crore in June

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: GST collections rose 14 per cent to about Rs 1.95 lakh crore in June on higher tax mop-up from imports as well as domestic supplies, government data showed on Wednesday.

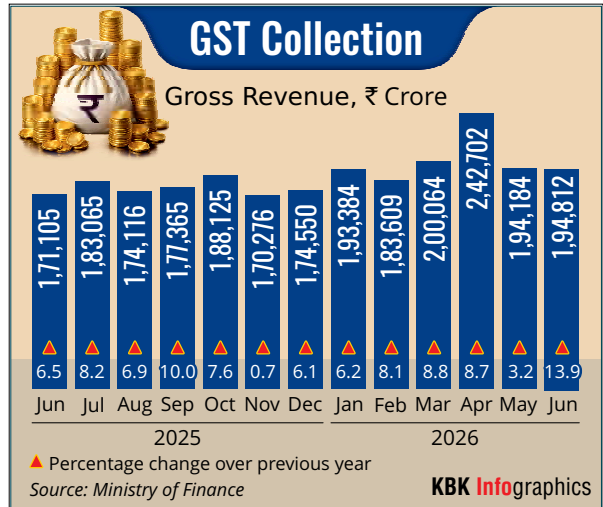
Gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenues were over Rs 1.94 lakh crore in May and Rs 1.71 lakh crore in June 2025.

As per the data, gross collections from domestic transactions were up 6.5 per cent to about Rs 1.35 lakh crore. These include central GST (CGST), state GST (SGST) and integrated GST (IGST) collection of Rs 37,376 crore, Rs 45,116 crore, and Rs 52,282 crore, respectively.

GST revenue from imports surged 34.6 per cent to Rs 60,038 crore in June.

Total refunds were up 29.1 per cent at Rs 32,436 crore in June. After adjusting refunds, net collection grew 11.2 per cent to over Rs 1.62 lakh crore in June.

Introduced on July 1, 2017,



GST replaced a complex system of 17 central and state taxes and 13 cesses with a unified indirect tax framework.

GST completed nine years of implementation this month.

During the first quarter of the current fiscal year, gross GST collection grew 8.4 per cent to about Rs 6.32 lakh crore. This includes a 2.8 per cent growth in tax revenues

from domestic transactions and a 26.2 per cent growth in imports.

Deloitte India Partner MS Mani said GST monthly collections inching closer to the Rs 2 lakh crore-mark in a month that saw significant economic disruptions due to the West Asia situation is a true reflection of the country's economic resilience.

Bijay Kumar Mohanty takes addl charge as IREDA CMD



NEW DELHI: Bijay Kumar Mohanty on Wednesday assumed additional charge as Chairman and Managing Director of the Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency Ltd. (IREDA), following the retirement of Pradip Kumar Das.

The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy has assigned Mohanty the additional responsibility for three months, or until a regular CMD is appointed, or until further orders, whichever is earlier. Mohanty has been serving as Director (Finance) of IREDA since October 12, 2023, and as the company's Chief Financial Officer since October 16, 2023. Before joining IREDA, he headed the Smart Metering Division at REC Power Development and Consultancy Ltd. and also served as Senior General Manager (Finance and Accounts) at REC Ltd.

A fellow member of the Institute of Cost Accountants of India, Mohanty holds multiple degrees in commerce, public administration and law, besides a doctorate in commerce from the Kalinga Institute of Industrial Technology, Bhubaneswar. He has over 27 years of experience across IREDA, REC, CESCO and GRIDCO. **MP05T**

NBCC bags deal to build Andhra Bhavan in Delhi

NEW DELHI: State-owned NBCC (India) Ltd. has signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the Andhra Pradesh government to plan, design and construct the new Andhra Pradesh Bhavan in the national capital at an estimated cost of Rs 105.5 crore, excluding GST and project management consultancy (PMC) charges.

The project will be executed on a turnkey deposit work basis and is proposed to have a built-up area of around 2.49 lakh square feet. The MoU was signed by Andhra Pradesh Bhavan Resident Commissioner Pravin Kumar, IAS, and NBCC Chief General Manager (Engineering) Anil Kumar in the presence of NBCC Chairman and Managing Director K.P. Mahadevaswamy, Andhra Pradesh Bhavan Special Commissioner Arja Srikanth and NBCC Director (Commercial) Suman Kumar.

As the designated executing agency, NBCC will be respon-



sible for the entire project lifecycle, including preparation of architectural concept plans, detailed structural designs, contract management, open tendering and construction.

The two sides have also agreed to sign a separate agreement at a later stage for handing over the annual maintenance of the building to NBCC or one of its subsidiaries for a minimum period of five years.

According to the company, the new Andhra Pradesh Bhavan is being envisioned as a landmark structure showcasing modern governance and contemporary architecture in New Delhi. **MP05T**

Markets bounce back after 2 days of decline; Sensex jumps 444 pts

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded on Wednesday after two days of decline amid a positive trend in global markets and fall in crude oil prices.

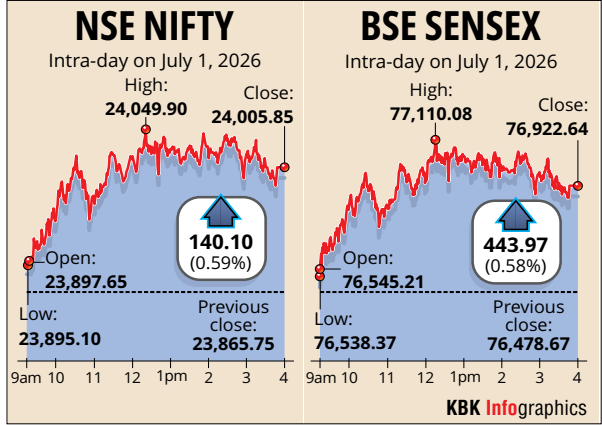
The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 443.97 points, or 0.58 per cent, to settle at 76,922.64. During the day, it jumped 631.41 points, or 0.82 per cent, to 77,110.08.

The 50-share NSE Nifty rallied 140.10 points, or 0.59 per cent, to end at 24,005.85.

From the Sensex pack, Eternal, Asian Paints, Hindustan Unilever, Adani Ports, Mahindra & Mahindra, and State Bank of India were among the major winners. HCL Tech, Tech Mahindra, Tata Consultancy Services, Tata Steel, and Infosys were among the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 1.07 per cent to USD 72.17 per barrel.

The BSE MidCap Select



index edged marginally higher by 0.20 per cent and SmallCap Select index eked out a marginal gain of 0.02 per cent.

Sectorally, realty jumped 3.56 per cent, FMCG (1.76 per cent), services (1.35 per cent), consumer discretionary (1.20 per cent), auto (1.10 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (0.97 per cent) and PSU bank (0.81 per cent).

Focused IT tumbled 2.53

per cent, IT (1.94 per cent), metal (0.87 per cent) and telecommunication (0.34 per cent).

Meanwhile, the rupee depreciated 60 paise to close at 95.16 against the US dollar on Wednesday, as a strengthening dollar index weighed on emerging market currencies.

Moreover, market sentiment turned highly cautious, following the breach of the psychological level of 95.00.

Jindal Steel secures CARE AA+ rating upgrade

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Jindal Steel on Wednesday said CARE Ratings has upgraded its long-term credit rating to CARE AA+ (Stable) from CARE AA (Stable), citing the company's strong financial profile, prudent capital management and sustained business performance.

The rating agency also reaffirmed the company's CARE A1+ rating for its short-term bank facilities. In addition, CARE Ratings upgraded

In addition, CARE Ratings upgraded the rating for Jindal Steel's proposed NCD issue to CARE AA+ (Stable)

the rating for Jindal Steel's proposed Non-Convertible Debenture (NCD) issue to CARE AA+ (Stable) from CARE AA (Stable).

In a further boost to the group's credit profile, CARE

Ratings upgraded the long-term bank facilities rating of Jindal Steel Odisha Ltd, a wholly owned subsidiary of Jindal Steel, to CARE AA+ (Stable) from CARE AA (Stable), while reaffirming its CARE A1+ rating for short-term bank facilities.

According to the company, the rating upgrade reflects its robust operational performance, strong balance sheet, disciplined financial management and continued focus on sustainable long-term value creation.

It said the improved rating is expected to enhance financial flexibility and strengthen its ability to access capital efficiently to support future growth plans.

Jindal Steel said the detailed rating rationale has been published by CARE Ratings as part of the company's regulatory disclosures and is also available on its website. The company is among India's leading integrated steel producers, with operations across multiple manufacturing facilities in the country and overseas.

SK Sinha takes over as GAIL Director (Finance)

NEW DELHI: GAIL (India) on Wednesday said S K Sinha has assumed charge as Director (Finance).

Sinha, who previously served as Executive Director (Finance & Accounts), succeeds to the board after more than three decades with the company. He joined GAIL as a management trainee in 1994. He replaces R K Jain, who superannuated on June 30.

A Cost and Management Accountant, Sinha has worked



across corporate finance, accounting, treasury, taxation, budgeting, project evaluation, investor relations and mergers and acquisitions during his tenure at the company. **MP05T**

SBI boosts AI-powered banking

NEW DELHI: State Bank of India (SBI) on Tuesday marked its 71st Foundation Day by unveiling a range of artificial intelligence (AI)-powered digital initiatives aimed at enhancing retail and business banking services for its over 53 crore customers.

The country's largest lender said the new offerings, introduced through its YONO platform, include AI-enabled features, simplified digital journeys and industry-first innovations designed to make banking more convenient, intelligent and customer-centric.

Among the key additions for retail customers is a seamless 3-in-1 digital onboarding process that allows new users to open a savings account along with a demat and trading account with SBICAP Securities Ltd. Eligible customers can also convert a regular savings account into a corporate salary account or upgrade an existing salary account entirely online.

SBI has also launched what it describes as an industry-first sustainability feature on YONO. The new journey enables customers to monitor the carbon emissions saved through digital banking transactions and track a monthly "green score".

For business customers, the bank has expanded the capabilities of YONO Business by integrating its complete Trade Finance suite into the mobile platform.

It also launched YONO Ji, an Agentic AI-powered virtual assistant available round the clock on YONO Business web and mobile platforms.

SBI chairman CS Setty said that the latest initiatives reflect SBI's commitment to leveraging AI, digital innovation and data-driven insights to simplify banking while supporting India's journey towards Viksit Bharat 2047. **MP05T**

Hero's VIDA unveils new brand identity

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: VIDA, the electric mobility brand powered by Hero, on Wednesday unveiled a refreshed brand identity as it looks to expand beyond electric scooters into a broader future mobility ecosystem.

The rebranding marks the next phase of VIDA's journey since its global debut in 2022. The company said the brand has evolved from offering a single premium electric scooter to a wider portfolio that now includes family and commuter electric scooters, the DIRT.E off-road range and the future mobility platform NOVUS.

At the core of the refreshed identity is a new geometric V-Lettermark derived from the logo of its parent brand, Hero.

According to the company, the design retains the left pillar of Hero's "H", symbolising trust, engineering excellence and scale, while a 30-degree forward tilt reflects progress and innovation. The refreshed identity also introduces "The VOOM" — a kinetic visual mark, motion language and electric sonic signature designed for use across vehicles and digital interfaces.



The company said the new logo, featuring black, white and vibrant orange, represents strength, clarity, optimism and movement while reinforcing that VIDA continues to be "powered by Hero", leveraging the credibility of the world's largest manufacturer of motorcycles and scooters.

Commenting on the launch, Hero MotoCorp Executive Chairman Pawan Munjal said true progress is rooted in a trusted legacy while embracing bold new directions.

He said VIDA, which means "Life", was launched in 2022 to create meaningful impact through sustainable mobility, and over the past four years its purpose has grown into a broader movement aimed at building a better world through accessible, clean and dependable mobility solutions.

RBI appoints Ravi Shankar as Executive Director

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday appointed Ravi Shankar as its new Executive Director (ED), with effect from July 1.

Prior to his elevation, Shankar served as Adviser-In-Charge of the Department of Statistics and Information Management. In his new role, he will continue to head the department, the RBI said.

A career central banker with over three decades of experience, Shankar has worked across several key areas of the RBI, including corporate and banking statistics, the government securities market, settlement systems, debt management and survey-related functions. He has also been a member of several committees and working groups dealing with macroeconomic statistics and policy-related issues.

Shankar holds a Master's degree in Statistics from Banaras Hindu University. He also has a Diploma in Development Policy and Planning from the Institute of Economic Growth, Delhi. **MP05T**

India imported record crude volumes in June despite tensions in West Asia

Russian supplies made up for more than half of country's overall imports

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India imported 4.93 million barrels per day (bpd) of crude oil in June, the highest volume for the month on record, despite geopolitical tensions in West Asia, according to data and analysis from energy intelligence firm Kpler.

Russian crude imports rose to around 2.6 million bpd during the month, reinforcing Russia's position as India's largest oil supplier, Kpler analyst Sumit Ritolia said. Russian supplies made up for more than half of the country's overall imports in June, up from 36.5 per cent in May when it had imported 2.13 million bpd from Moscow, according to Kpler data.

Russia has been India's largest crude supplier since 2022-23, as Indian refiners increased purchases of discounted Russian oil after many European buyers reduced imports following Moscow's invasion of Ukraine. The record import volumes underscore India's ability to maintain crude supplies through diversified sourcing



even as conflict in West Asia raised concerns over global energy shipments and briefly pushed up oil prices.

"India's crude imports have quietly demonstrated remarkable resilience over the past 100 days. Over the past 100 days, India has arguably been one of the best-positioned major importers, successfully maintaining crude inflows through proactive diversification and procurement strategies," he said. Indian refiners have largely secured crude supplies through the first half of August, as cargoes are typically booked one to two months in advance, Ritolia said. That leaves refiners with limited immediate need for additional purchases even if

INSIGHT

» India imported 4.93 million bpd of crude in June

» Russian crude imports rose to around 2.6 million bpd during June

geopolitical risks persist.

"India imported 4.93 million bpd of crude in June, the highest June volume on record, despite heightened geopolitical tensions in the Middle East. At the same time, Russian crude imports climbed to around 2.6 million bpd, reaffirming Russia's position as India's largest and most important crude supplier," he said.

The ability to sustain record import levels while increasing purchases from Russia underscores the success of Indian refiners in diversifying supply and managing refinery economics, he added.

Looking ahead, global crude supplies are expected to remain adequate, supported by higher

exports from Africa, Russia and Venezuela, increased output by OPEC+ producers and the continued movement of oil through the Strait of Hormuz, he said. The recent decline in international crude prices also suggests the market is becoming less concerned about near-term supply disruptions.

Ritolia said he does not expect a meaningful resumption of Iranian crude imports into India in the near term.

While one or two opportunistic cargoes could arrive in July or August, refiners are already largely covered for feedstock requirements through early August. Any sustained return of Iranian crude would depend on the regulatory environment after the current sanctions waiver expires on August 21, he said.

India, the world's third-largest importer and consumer of crude oil, meets more than 88 per cent of its oil requirement through imports and has sharply increased purchases of discounted Russian crude since 2022.



‘Just for the dance or the song’

Actress Samantha Ruth Prabhu talked about women’s roles in cinema

Samantha Ruth Prabhu recently spoke openly about steering away from the typical action-driven, male-centric storytelling and didn't shy away from admitting the film's path to release was far from smooth.

The actress also noted what makes this achievement feel especially close to her heart: the fact that Raj Nidimoru was behind it not just as producer, but as the writer of its story as well.

Speaking in an interview about her recent film 'Maa Inti Bangaaram', Samantha shared, "What drew me to the story? I really wasn't looking at it as genre-breaking or trying to make a statement. I saw it as this compelling character with real depth



‘I think that audiences have changed. They’re more open to fresher stories,’ she says

and it had a lot of scope to entertain and I feel that’s

really rare, especially for women in cinema. Also, I think that the action is not really a spectacle. I think that it’s about time that we stop putting women in cinema just for the spectacle, just for the dance or a song or a role, just for the spectacle.”

“I think that audiences have changed; they’re more open to fresher stories and no longer asking whether a hero is male or female. They simply want to be entertained; they want to be moved. If a character is written honestly and the story connects, people will embrace it and I believe that’s the direction mainstream cinema is heading towards and I’m happy to be a part of that journey,” she added.

AGENCIES

‘Mupapa’ gets a new release date



Bollywood actor Ayushmann Khurrana is helming this project

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Yash Raj Films’ and ‘Posham Pa Pictures’ first theatrical collaboration, ‘Mupapa’, is headlined by Ayushmann Khurrana.

Produced by YRF’s CEO Akshaye Widhani, whose last film ‘Saiyaara’ became the highest-grossing romantic film in the history of Indian cinema, ‘Mupapa’ is directed by Sameer Saxena and is set to release on February 19, 2027.

‘Mupapa’ is a genre-bending theatrical film. Ayush-

A genre-bending theatrical film, it is produced by YRF’s CEO, Akshaye Widhani

mann, who has made content disruption his calling card, is helming this project that will keep the audience at the edge of their seats from the word go.

The actor was last seen in the comedy ‘Pati Patni Aur Woh Do’ in May 2026 and the film tanked at the box office.

Amit Trivedi comes on board for Rishab Shetty’s film

The two-part historical magnum opus is titled ‘The Pride of Bharat: Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Pritam, who was originally composing the music for the film, recently announced a break from mainstream films. The makers have now brought Amit Trivedi on board to helm the music for Sandeep Singh’s ambitious two-part historical magnum opus, titled ‘The Pride of Bharat: Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj’.

With ‘Kantara’ star Rishab Shetty portraying Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, the film has already generated tremendous buzz. It is being mounted as one of the biggest pan-India cinematic spectacles ever made on the legendary Maratha warrior.

The project marks a significant first for the National Award-winning composer, as it will be his first Hindi historical film based on the life and legacy of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. National Award-winning lyricist Prasoon Joshi, who has been associated with the project from the beginning, will continue to pen the lyrics, bringing together a powerful creative collaboration for this ambitious historical epic.

A source close to the production shared, “The team firmly believes Amit Trivedi is the perfect creative force to bring this epic to life musically. His ability to blend powerful orchestration with deeply rooted Indian melodies, combined with Prasoon Joshi’s powerful writing, makes for an exceptional creative

It’s being mounted as one of the biggest pan-India cinematic spectacles ever made on the legendary Maratha warrior

partnership. The music has to reflect the courage, vision, emotion and legacy of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj and we are confident this soundtrack will become one of the defining highlights of the film.”

Directed by Sandeep Singh, ‘The Pride of Bharat: Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj’ is being mounted on a massive budget and is envisioned as one of the biggest cinematic spectacles ever made on the legendary Maratha warrior. Planned as a two-part cinematic saga, the film stars Shetty in the titular role, alongside Arjun Rampal, Vivek Oberoi and an ensemble cast.

The magnum opus is scheduled to go on the floors later this year. With Trivedi now helming the music and Joshi penning the lyrics, the makers are confident that the soundtrack and background score will elevate the scale, emotion and grandeur of this landmark tribute to one of India’s greatest icons.



Prime Video reveals first-look images of ‘Neagley’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video’ released first-look images and announced the premiere date for the highly anticipated debut action series ‘Neagley’.

Featuring Maria Sten as the fan-favourite title character, ‘Neagley’ invites fans of the ‘Reacher’ series and Lee Child’s best-selling novels deeper into the world they love, delivering a gripping new mystery packed with unexpected twists.

‘Reacher’ season four will return on August 12, 2026, with the first three episodes and a new episode weekly through

September 16. Upon the season four finale, all eight episodes of ‘Neagley’ will be released on September 16, 2026, exclusively on ‘Prime Video’.

Frances Neagley (Maria Sten) is a private investigator in Chicago and a former military protégé of Jack Reacher (Alan Ritchson) in the Army’s 110th Special Investigations Unit. When she learns that a beloved friend from her past has been killed in a suspicious accident, she becomes hell-bent on justice. Using everything she’s learned from Jack Reacher and her time as a member of the 110 Spe-

cial Investigators, Neagley puts herself on a dangerous path to uncover a menacing evil.

Starring Maria Sten as Frances Neagley, the ensemble cast features Greyston Holt as Detective Hudson Riley, Adeline Rudolph as Renee Birdwhistle, Jasper Jones as Keno, Matthew Del Negro as Pierce Woodrow and Damon Herriman as Lawrence Cole. Alan Ritchson guest stars as Jack Reacher.

Based on the character in novels by Lee Child, Neagley is produced by ‘Paramount Television Studios’ and ‘Amazon MGM Studios’.

INDIAN CINEMA’S MOST CELEBRATED FILM—IFFM to celebrate 25 years of ‘Lagaan’ with Aamir Khan in attendance

Actor-producer Aamir Khan will attend a special screening of his acclaimed film ‘Lagaan’ at the 17th edition of the Indian Film Festival of Melbourne, the organisers announced.

The festival, billed as the largest celebration of Indian cinema outside India, will be held from August 13 to 23 in Melbourne.

The film gala’s curtain-raiser event on July 9 will commemorate the 25th anniversary of ‘Lagaan’, the Ashutosh Gowariker-directed period sports drama which remains one of Indian cinema’s most celebrated films and was nominated for the Academy Award for ‘Best Foreign Language Film’.

Khan will attend the special screening at ACMI cinema in Melbourne, officially launching this year’s festival celebrations, according to a press release.

Festival director Mitu Bhowmick Lange said marking 25 years of ‘Lagaan’ was a fitting way to begin the festival.

“The Indian Film Festival of Melbourne has always celebrated stories that have made a lasting impact on audiences and there could not have been a better way to begin our 17th edition than by celebrating 25 years of ‘Lagaan’.

The film is a milestone in Indian cinema and continues to inspire generations of filmmakers and audiences around the world. We are delighted to welcome Aamir Khan to Melbourne for this special celebration and look forward to presenting another memorable edition of the festival that brings together the very best of Indian cinema,” Lange said.



The festival will be held from August 13 to 23 in Melbourne

Backed by the Government of Victoria, the Indian Film Festival of Melbourne has emerged as a major international platform for Indian cinema over the years.

PTI

Adarsh Gourav says he embraces anonymity

‘Not being recognised is actually normal,’ he says

Adarsh Gourav feels happy that he isn’t a recognisable face in public despite a filmography of many critical hits and finds the anonymity quite normal. The actor has stepped into documentary storytelling with ‘Voices of the Land’, a new series that explores the rich cultural heritage of India’s northeastern region.

And it was a place where people didn’t recognise him, who has proved his versatility as an artiste with varied performances in movies such as ‘The White Tiger’, ‘Mom’, ‘Kho Gaye Hum Kahan’, ‘Superboys of Malegaon’ and series ‘Guns & Gulaab’. “They were told that I was an actor, and I’m sure some of them Googled me later. They were like, ‘Okay, he’s done this film and that film,’” Gourav told PTI in an interview.

Asked if the anonymity was refreshing for him, the actor said, “I find that anonymity every day. I’m not that recogni-



The actor has stepped into documentary storytelling with ‘Voices of the Land’

sable. The kind of films that I’ve done have largely been niche films. They aren’t huge commercial films that release on 5,000 screens across the country.”

He said it is difficult for actors, who are either stars or rising stars, to remain anonymous in public. “For me, not being recognised is actually normal. So not being recognised in the Northeast felt like normal life. The day everybody starts

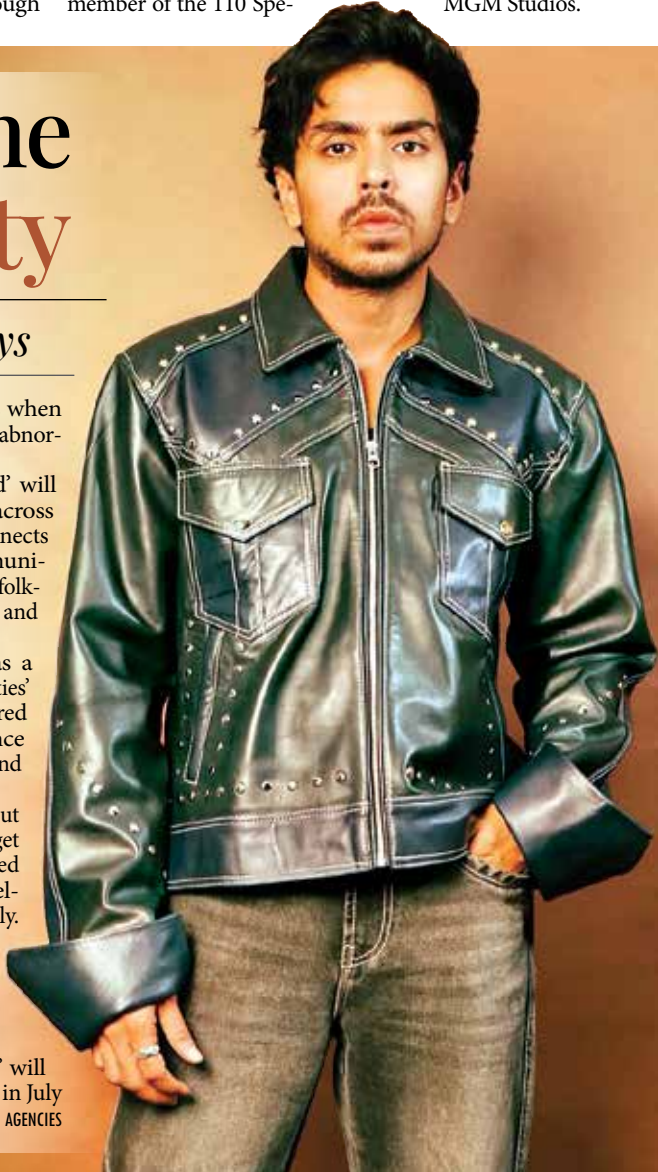
recognising me - that’s when things will start feeling abnormal,” he said.

‘Voices of the Land’ will see Gourav journey across the Northeast as he connects with indigenous communities through their music, folklore, rituals, oral histories and everyday lives.

Gourav said he has a ‘very low threshold for cities’ and the docuseries offered him a chance to distance himself from the hustle and bustle of urban life.

“I just wanted to get out of the rut of the city and get away from anything related to urban life. I start feeling saturated very quickly. If I don’t run away to a place that has a lot of nature every few weeks, I start feeling burnt out,” he said.

‘Voices of the Land’ will premiere on ‘JioHotstar’ in July 2026.



AGENCIES

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER

For and on behalf of the President of India, the Dy. Chief Engineer (CON), South Eastern Railway, Kharagpur, invites E-tender for the following work. Following tender has been uploaded on website www.ireps.gov.in. The tender will be closed at 12.00 hrs. on due date. **e-Tender Notice No.: DCE-CON-II-KGP-11-2026, Date: 30.06.2026**, Brief Description of work: Tender Schedule for laying of rail Track connectivity to the LHB PH-I & II under Jurisdiction of Dy. CE/CON-II/Kharagpur, South Eastern Railway. **Cost:** ₹ 1,00,43,886.40. **EMD:** ₹ 2,00,900. **Completion Period:** 12 (Twelve) months. **Closing Date:** 30.07.2026. Interested tenderers may visit website www.ireps.gov.in for full details/description/specification of the tenders and submit their bids online. In no case manual tender for this item will be accepted. **N.B.:** Prospective bidders may regularly visit www.ireps.gov.in to participate in all other tenders. (PR-402)

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS!

IMPORTANT INFORMATION

EXTENSION OF PERIODICITY OF SUMMER SPECIAL TRAINS

This is notified for the information of Rail Passengers that Railways have decided to extend the Periodicity of the run of following Summer Special Trains as under:-

Train No.	Station		Frequency/ Days of Run	Earlier Notified Upto	Extended Period		Trips
	From	To			From	To	
07621	Hazur Sahib Nanded	Hazrat Nizamuddin	Weekly (Saturday)	27.06.2026	04.07.2026	25.07.2026	04
07622	Hazrat Nizamuddin	Hazur Sahib Nanded	Weekly (Sunday)	28.06.2026	05.07.2026	26.07.2026	04
09609	Udaipur City	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	Weekly (Tuesday)	30.06.2026	07.07.2026	28.07.2026	04
09610	Yog Nagari Rishikesh	Udaipur City	Weekly (Wednesday)	01.07.2026	08.07.2026	29.07.2026	04

Rest other information will hold good.

For detailed information regarding stoppages and timings of above trains, please call RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit enquiry website www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in

Please join us on

Visit RailMadad Website: www.railmadad.indianrailways.gov.in
Download RailMadad app

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Always at your service
Visit us at : www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

GOVERNMENT OF PUNJAB
PATIALA URBAN PLANNING & DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
PUDA Complex, Urban Estate Phase-II, Patiala
E-Tender No. 175/PDA/DE(C)/2026/13480-487 dated 26-06-2026

Divisional Engineer (Civil), PDA, Patiala invites online bids for "Development of Commercial Pocket-B (5.18 Acres) and Pocket -C (4.14 Acres), Urban Estate Phase-2, Patiala (DNIT Amount: Rs. 955.98 Lacs)."

Closing date & time: 13-07-2026 at 11.00 AM

For details log on to: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

NOTE: Any corrigendum(s) to the tender notice shall be published on the above website only

PR-Advt. No :- 1319/12/2026-27/12837

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 (ii) Cr. P.C.

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Raju S/o Sohan Lal R/o H.No. B-2T, Sheesh Mahal Enclave, Prem Nagar, Kirari Suleman Nagar, Delhi**, have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 80/2020 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act.**, has been registered at **PS: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Raju** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Raju** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Raju** of under has been under **FIR No. 80/2020 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act.**, registered at **PS: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Bharti Beniwal
DJ/8852/ON/2026
(Court Notice)
Ld. JMFC-05, Room No. 114
Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sonu @ Sohan Lal S/o Ratan Lal R/o H.No. 1/94, Block-I, Khichripur, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 319/20, U/S 379 IPC, PS Karol Bagh, Central Distt., New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sonu @ Sohan Lal** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sonu @ Sohan Lal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Sonu @ Sohan Lal** the said accused of **FIR No. 319/20, U/S 379 IPC, PS Karol Bagh, Central Distt., New Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Nishat Bangarh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01, (Central), Court No.-180,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DJ/8528/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice
Invitation of tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

N.I.T. No. 05 (A,B,C,D,E,F,G,H,I,J,K,L,M,N,O)/26-27/WE

Name of work with its location (A) Annual general repair and white washing painting of staff qtrs and service buildings in Loco colony/DEE for period ending 30.06.2027 in the section of SSE/W/DKZ-I under ADEN/E-HV/DLI.

(B) Annual general repair and white washing, painting of staff qtrs and service building for period ending 30.06.2027 in the section of SSE/W/DKZ-I under ADEN/E-HV/DLI

(C) Annual Zone Work of staff Quarters and service building for period year 30.06.2027 in the S/o SSE/W/DKZ-II under ADEN/E-IV.

(D) Annual general work of staff Qtrs. and service building for the period of 30.06.2027 in the section of SSE/W/E/SSB Under ADEN/E-IV.

(E) Annual zone work of White Washing and Painting of staff quarters and service buildings at Punjabi Bagh, Dayabasti, Rampura, Pandav Nagar, Wazirpur, RPF-RPSF complex, Printing Press/SSB and Electric Workshop DBSI for the period ending 30-06-2027 in the section of SSE/W/Punjabi Bagh under ADEN/E-IV.

(F) Annual zone work of staff quarters and service buildings at Basanti Lane and Ajmeri gate side railway colony and other offices for period ending 30.06.2027 in the section of SSE/W/PWG under ADEN/E-I.

(G) Annual zone work of staff quarters and service buildings at P.K Road for period ending 30.06.2027 in the section of SSE/W/PWG under ADEN/E-I.

(H) Annual general repair and white washing, painting of staff qtrs. Bungalow and service building for year ending 30.06.2027 in the section of SSE/W/TH under ADEN/E-I.

(I) Annual zone work of staff Qtrs. And Service building of Sarojini Nagar, Lajpat Nagar, Gulabi Bagh, HN2M, jangpura and okhla Railway colony for P.E for 30.06.2027 in the section of SSE/W/HN2M under ADEN/E-III

(J) Annual Zone work for Type-V, Type-VI flats and service buildings at Chankya Rail Enclave for period ending 30.06.2027 in the S/o SSE/W/HN2M under ADEN/E-III.

(K) Supply & maintenance of Indoor and outdoor well developed ornamental potted plants at Hazrat Nizamuddin Railway Station in the S/o JE/Hort./HN2M under ADEN/Hort./NDLS.

(L) Repair & Maintenance of Parks under ADEN/Hort./NDLS.

(M) Annual maintenance of lawn, parks & hedges in the S/o SSE/Hort./DKZ under ADEN/Hort./NDLS.

(N) Annual maintenance of lawn, Parks and Hedges in the S/o SSE/Hort./SPM under ADEN/Hort./NDLS

(O) Maintenance of Nursery, Aesthetic improvement of the inner & outer green belt & Landscaping at Rail Bhawan in the S/o SSE/Hort./SPM under ADEN/Hort./NDLS.

Approx. cost of work (A) 10999782.44 (B) 12999139.00 (C) 11999419.51 (D) 8999675.54 (E) 14999488.67 (F) 9999986.93 (G) 9999672.78 (H) 11999582.68 (I) 12999759.31 (J) 12999763.40 (K) 9994561.92 (L) 7999999.95 (M) 11999985.53 (N) 9999834.59 (O) 3099210.09

EMD amount (A) 220000.00 (B) 260000.00 (C) 240000.00 (D) 180000.00 (E) 300000.00 (F) 200000.00 (G) 200000.00 (H) 240000.00 (I) 260000.00 (J) 260000.00 (K) 199900.00 (L) 160000.00 (M) 240000.00 (N) 200000.00 (O) 62000.00

Completion period of work (A) 12 Months (B) 12 Months (C) 12 Months (D) 12 Months (E) 12 Months (F) 12 Months (G) 12 Months (H) 12 Months (I) 12 Months (J) 12 Months (K) 24 Months (L) 24 Months (M) 16 Months (N) 20 Months (O) 12 Months

Date and Time for submission of tender and opening of tender Closing date of tender on 24.07.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Website particular notice board location complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc. Above tender available on website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

No: 128-W/269/O.E./T/NIT No. 05 (A,B,C,D,E,F,G,H,I,J,K,L,M,N,O)/26-27/WE Dated: -25.06.2026 2243/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, intends to invite following online Two Part Domestic Competitive Bidding (DCB) Tender for the following works:

Tender No. T25P640001: Augmentation of 02 nos 500 MVA, ICT along with associated equipment & accessories including civil work at 400 kV Substation Harsh Vihar & 400 kV Bawana on Turnkey basis..

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. : 2026_DTL_294614_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0070-010726

Last date for bid submission:- 18.08.2026 at 01.30 P.M .

All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/ Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSONS

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bhartiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **1. Farukh @ Sohel S/o Bandukhan R/o E-3638, J.J. Colony, Bawana, Delhi & 2. Sonu S/o Som Nath R/o K-271, J.J. Colony, Bawana, Delhi** have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence **FIR No. 694/2015 u/s 392/411/34 IPC** at **P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **1. Farukh @ Sohel & 2. Sonu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **1. Farukh @ Sohel & 2. Sonu** have absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding **u/s 82 Cr.P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita** have been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **1. Farukh @ Sohel & 2. Sonu** of **FIR No. 694/2015 u/s 392/411/34 IPC** at **P.S. Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **07.08.2026**.

By Order: **Ms. Bharti Beniwal,**
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05, (North)
Room No. 114, 1st Floor,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8550/ON/2026

GAIL Gas Limited
(A wholly owned subsidiary of GAIL (India) Limited)

NOTICE FOR HIRING OF CONTRACTORS FOR CGD PROJECT

GAIL Gas Limited intends to engage experienced contractors/agencies through an **On-Spot Walk-In Selection Process** for execution of **DPNG LMC/GI and MDPE Laying Works** in the Sonipat, Meerut, Dewas, Raisen, Sehore-Shajapur (RSS), Puri-Ganjam-Nayagarh and Seraikela Kharsawan & West Singhbhum (Geographical Area (GA)).

The Walk-In Selection Process shall be conducted as per the schedule given below:-

Geographical Area (GA)	Scope of Work	Date & Time
Sonipat	DPNG LMC/GI Works	
Meerut	DPNG LMC/GI Works	03.07.2026, 06.07.2026 &
Dewas	PE Laying Works	
Raisen-Sehore-Shajapur	DPNG LMC/GI and PE Laying Works	07.07.2026, 10:00 AM to 5:30 PM
Puri-Ganjam-Nayagarh	PE Laying Works	
Seraikela Kharsawan & West Singhbhum	DPNG LMC/GI and PE Laying Works	

Venue: Conference Room, 3rd Floor, GAIL Gas Limited, GAIL Jubilee Tower, B-3536, Sector-1, Noida- 201301 (U.P.)

However, interested bidders shall also have the option to submit their documents at Sites. Addresses of sites can be referred in respective RFQ.

Eligibility & Documents Required:

Interested bidders are required to submit relevant supporting documents, including but not limited to, Work Experience Certificates/Completion Certificate, Registration Certificate, PAN Card, PF Registration Certificate (wherever applicable), ESI Registration Certificate (wherever applicable), Details of available manpower, machinery, and equipment required for execution of the works.

The bidder shall submit a copy of at least one work order awarded during the last seven (07) years as proof of experience in execution of PNG connection/pipeline-related works in the gas, water supply, drainage, telecom, or any other utility sector for GAIL/GAIL Gas and/or their Group Companies, or for any other company.

The Walk-In Selection Process is scheduled to be conducted over the above-mentioned three days. However, if the selection process concludes earlier, no requests for submission of bids from bidders will be entertained thereafter.

Detailed Terms & Conditions: Detailed Terms & Conditions are available at <https://gailgas.com/eoi/expressions-interest>.

Contact Persons:

- Mr. Anrab Samanta- amab.samanta@gail.co.in | Mobile: 7055515333
- Mr. Sandeep Sharma- sandeep.sharma1@gail.co.in | Mobile: 959477955
- Mr. Saksham Gupta- saksham.gupta@gail.co.in | Mobile: 9988092246
- Mr. Anil Kumar- anil.kumar1@gail.co.in | Mobile: 7763807378

Important Note: Any corrigendum, addendum, clarification, or amendment to this Notice shall be hosted only on the GAIL Gas website. Interested bidders are therefore advised to visit the website regularly for updates.

Corporate Identification Number : U40200DL2008G0178614

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jklpolice.gov.in
Hue and Cry Notice
Rule No. 712/191

SHO P/S Akhnoor, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Sant Ram S/O Khushi Ram caste Brahman R/O Pacca Danga, District Jammu is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 244/1995 U/S 379 RPC of P/S Akhnoor, Jammu, since the commission of crime. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded. It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name	: Sant Ram
S/O	: Khushi Ram
Address	: Pacca Danga, District Jammu
Height	: 5' 07"
Complexion	: Wheatish
Eyes	: Black

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1.DPO, Jammu	: 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail ID	: sspjammu@jklpolice.gov.in
3.PCR Jammu	: 0191-2605949
4.SP Rural Jammu	: 0191-2605949
5.SDPO Akhnoor	: 01924-252244
6.SHO P/S Akhnoor	: 01924-252225

Sd/-
For Sr. Superintendent of Police
Jammu

DIP No:DIP/J-4796/26

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE

The Chief Engineer/Const./RSP/NR, 901 B, Tower-1, 9th Floor, Konnectus Tower, DMRC Building, Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi-110002 for and on behalf of the President of India invites e-tender under Two Packet System for the under noted work:-

1. Full Name of Work	Construction of 4 ROB's (i) 2 lane ROB in lieu of LC- C-28 at KM. 18/1-2 on Jalandhar Cantt - Hoshiarpur section of Firozpur Division (ii) 2 lane ROB in lieu of LC-48 at KM. 71.461 on Bathinda - Shri Ganganagar section of Ambala Division (iii) 2 lane ROB in lieu of LC-B-20 at KM. 28/0-1 on Bathinda -Sriganganagar section of Ambala Division (iv) 2 lane ROB in lieu of LC-58 at KM.86.541 on Bathinda -Sriganganagar section of Ambala Division (including LHS) of Northern Railway under the Road Safety Projects Unit (RSPU)/NR New Delhi.
2. Approx. Cost of work	Rs 1,96,02,44,048.11/- Rupees Only (One Hundred Ninety-Six Crore Two Lakh Forty-Four Thousand Forty-Eight Rupees and Eleven Paise Only.)
3. Completion period of the works	18 months Period
4. Earnest Money to be deposited	3,92,04,900.00/- Rupees only (Three Crore Ninety-Two Lakh Four Thousand Nine Hundred Rupees Only.)
5. Sale/availability of tender document on Rly. Website	Tender document will be available on IREPS web site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 30.06.2026 to 24.07.2026.
6. Last date/Time of upload of tenders	Tender documents can be uploaded on IREPS website upto 24-07-2026, 11:30 hrs.
7. Date and time of opening of tender	Any time after 24.07.2026, 11:30 hrs.
8. Pre bid Conference	Date: 07.07.2026 Time: 12:00 Hrs to 13:00 Hrs. Venue: Office of CAO/C/RSP 9th Floor Konnectus Tower, DMRC Building, Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi-110002 and through online V/Link (uploaded on IREPS).

No. 26-W-09-2026-WA-DyCE-C-RSP Dated: 30.06.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2246/26

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Vinod S/o Late Sh. Liliu R/o H. No. 3213, Mahendra Park, Rani Bagh** also at **Jhuggi No. B-46/47, Larence Road, Balmiki Camp, Rampur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 331/10 U/s 302/396/412/460 IPC, PS Rani Bagh, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Vinod** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Vinod** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Vinod** in **FIR No. 331/10 U/s 302/396/412/460 IPC, PS Rani Bagh, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.08.2026**.

By order
Ms. Anuradha Jindal
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DJ/8702/OD/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE

Following e-tenders invites by the Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, Divisional Railway Manager's Office, North Central Railway, Prayagraj on behalf of President of India in the prescribed form, from the reputed contractors having sufficient experience and financial capacity :-

E-Tender Notice Number: GEM/2026/B/7718398 Dated 29.06.2026

Name of work: Tender for the provision of comprehensive management of parcel office activities at Kanpur Central Railway Station (CNB) for 1095 days (03 years) on outcome basis.

E-Tender Type: Two Packets System **Contract Period:** Three Years

Estimated Cost of Work (with GST): ₹ 11,00,94,048/-

Earnest Money: ₹ 22,01,900/-

Tender Closing Date and Time: 20.07.2026 16:00

Tender Opening Date and Time: 20.07.2026 16:30

Note: 1. Details of the above e-tender (including tender form) are available on the website of www.gem.gov.in from the date of publication till the date of opening of the tender. 2. For the above mentioned tender, only online bid will be accepted. For this purpose the vendor should register themselves on Gem website. 3. All documents to be attached should be signed by the tenderer. 4. E-tender forms will be issued free of cost to all tenderers. 5. For any technical issue please contact the helpline of GeM website. 148426(DG)

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **RIZWAN S/o Munney R/o Gali No. 14, Shashtri Park, Delhi** has committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 356/2018 U/s 379/34 IPC, PS Kashmere Gate, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **RIZWAN** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **RIZWAN** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation are hereby made that the said accused person(s) **RIZWAN** of **FIR No. 356/2018 U/s 379/34 IPC, PS Kashmere Gate, Delhi** are required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **18.08.2026 at 10:00 AM**.

By Order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate, First Class-II
Central Distt., Room No. 138
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DJ/8755/N/2026
(Court Matter)



AROUND THE WORLD

- » **IGNOU extends re-registration deadline till July 15**
- » **Canadian International School to host India's first Triathlon for kids**
- » **Parliamentary panel recommends separate entrance exams for medical courses**
- » **Goa Institute of Management-led research studies the impact of crude oil price hikes on global markets**



BUZZER ROUND

Q) WHO IS THE OLDEST PLAYER IN FIFA WORLD CUP 2026?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our June 25 edition question:
Brazil

Correct answers were sent by:
Ranajit Maitra, Animesh Poddar, Nandini Ghosh



NEWS & VIEWS

TeamLease Degree Apprenticeship has expanded its AI integrated apprenticeship programmes. Designed for both white-collar and blue-collar professionals, these programmes integrate practical AI learning into the apprenticeship journey, enabling learners to build workplace-ready AI capabilities while they earn.

ANNAM.AI, India's first Centre of Excellence (CoE) for AI in agriculture, hosted at IIT Ropar under the Ministry of Education, Government of India has launched HACK CORE 2026, a national AI hackathon in collaboration with Syngenta and Google, inviting innovators to develop AI-driven solutions for crop health, pest management and climate-resilient farming.

GLOBAL BOARDROOMS,
INDIAN MINDSMEET INDIAN-ORIGIN CEOs
POWERING WORLD'S
BIGGEST COMPANIES

Kolkata-born Shankh Mitra is the latest Indian-origin executive to join the ranks of global corporate heavyweights

URJA SAHA

In the last few days, you may have come across the name Shankh Mitra. If you're from Kolkata, there's an added reason to feel proud. This Jadavpur University alumnus is the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Welltower, a US-based real estate investment trust specialising in senior housing, healthcare facilities and wellness infrastructure. But that's not all. The Indian-origin business leader has reportedly been ranked as the world's second highest-paid CEO after receiving a reported compensation package worth US\$821 million. The recognition places him just behind Elon Musk, CEO of Tesla and SpaceX, in terms of disclosed CEO compensation packages. From Sundar Pichai (Google and Alphabet) and Satya Nadella (Microsoft) to Shantanu Narayen (Adobe) and Leena Nair (Chanel), Indian-origin leaders are at the helm of some of the world's biggest companies. *Millennium Post* takes a look at some of them.

Under his leadership, Google and Alphabet have significantly accelerated their focus on advanced artificial intelligence technologies.

ARVIND KRISHNA —
CHAIRMAN AND CEO, IBM

Born into a Telugu family in Andhra Pradesh, Arvind Krishna became IBM's CEO in 2020 after spending more than three decades with the company. He earned a BTech in electrical engineering from IIT Kanpur and a PhD in electrical engineering from the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign. He is widely recognised for steering the technology giant through a major transformation by focusing on hybrid cloud computing, enterprise AI and quantum computing.

SHANTANU NARAYEN —
CHAIRMAN, ADOBE

Born in Hyderabad, Shantanu Narayen has been instrumental in transforming Adobe into a global software powerhouse. He earned a bachelor's degree from Osmania University, a master's degree in computer science from Bowling Green State University, and an MBA from the University of California, Berkeley. His bold decision to shift Adobe from selling boxed software to a subscription-based cloud model revolutionised the creative software industry and established recurring revenue as the company's financial backbone. He joined Adobe in 1998 and became CEO in December 2007. In March 2026, he announced that he would step down as CEO once the board appoints his successor. He will continue to serve as Chairman of the Board.

SHANKH MITRA — CEO,
WELLTOWER

The latest Indian-origin executive to make international headlines is Kolkata-born Shankh Mitra. Born and raised in India, he earned a bachelor's degree in engineering from Jadavpur University before moving to the US, where he completed an MBA in Applied Value Investing from Columbia Business School. He now heads US healthcare real estate giant Welltower. Mitra reportedly is the world's second highest-paid CEO after Elon Musk, receiving a reported compensation package worth approximately US\$821 million.

SATYA NADELLA —
CHAIRMAN AND CEO,
MICROSOFT

Widely regarded as one of the most transformative corporate leaders of recent times, Hyderabad-born Satya Nadella has led Microsoft as its CEO since 2014, succeeding Steve Ballmer, and became the company's chairman in 2021. He holds a bachelor's degree in electrical engineering from the Manipal Institute of Technology, a master's degree in computer science from the University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee, and an MBA from the University of Chicago. He spearheaded Microsoft's pivot towards cloud computing, artificial intelligence and enterprise software, helping the company reclaim its position among the world's most valuable businesses.

LEENA NAIR — GLOBAL
CEO, CHANEL

Leena Nair is a British-Indian business executive serving as the Global CEO of the French luxury fashion house Chanel. Before joining Chanel in 2022, she spent nearly three decades at Unilever, where she made history as the company's first female, youngest-ever and first Asian Chief Human Resources Officer. She graduated in electronics and telecommunications engineering from Walchand College of Engineering, Sangli, and later earned an MBA from XLRI Jamshedpur, graduating as a gold medallist.

VASANT NARASIMHAN —
CEO, NOVARTIS

Physician and business leader Vasant Narasimhan has led Swiss pharmaceutical giant Novartis since 2018. He holds a bachelor's degree in biological sciences from the University of Chicago, an MD from Harvard Medical School, and a Master's in Public Policy from the Harvard Kennedy School. Under his leadership, Novartis has transformed into a focused, innovative medicines company with a strong emphasis on radiological therapy, gene and cell therapies, and RNA therapeutics. He was also recently appointed to the board of directors of the American AI company Anthropic.

SUNDAR PICHAI — CEO,
ALPHABET AND GOOGLE

From growing up in Chennai to leading Google's parent company, Alphabet, Sundar Pichai's journey has become synonymous with modern corporate success. The Indian-American business executive has served as CEO of Google since 2015 and of its parent company, Alphabet Inc., since 2019. He holds a bachelor's degree in metallurgical engineering from IIT Kharagpur, a master's degree in Materials Science and Engineering from Stanford University, and an MBA from the Wharton School of the University of Pennsylvania.

LOOK BEYOND THE CLASSROOM,
CHOOSE WISELY: SWAPAN DASGUPTA

National High School celebrates inter-school environmental awareness programme, Vanamahotsav 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

West Bengal Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta reminded students of National High School that a much bigger world exists beyond their school days. On Wednesday, the Padma Bhushan awardee and BJP's Rashbehari MLA visited the National High School CBSE campus on Hazra Road, Kolkata, to celebrate Vanamahotsav 2026 with the students.

Addressing the students, the eminent columnist and scholar said that they might not always find the curriculum exciting. "It happens and you might find the challenges of the classroom are not much. Hence, there is a natural inclination to look beyond it and look at other avenues of excitement. Now that's where the real problem arises," he said. Dasgupta emphasised that today's students are exposed to far more opportunities than those available during his own school days. He said that making the right choices would help them grow into more evolved individuals. "Otherwise, if you exercise the wrong options, then you won't fail, but you won't move on the fast track. So the idea, I think, for schools is to ensure that as many children as possible get on to the fast track," he said.

The idea of Vanamahotsav 2026 is to inspire students to become responsible custodians of nature. The event brought together students



from 23 schools across Kolkata, fostering a spirit of collective responsibility towards protecting and preserving the environment. One of the key highlights of the programme was a seed-sowing drive, during which students sowed seeds of neem, mahogany, areca palm and mango in pots. The saplings will be nurtured before being transplanted to suitable locations, thereby contributing to the city's green cover.

"These extracurricular activities are what make a school. More than the classroom, it's what happens outside the classroom that can actually shape the future," said Dasgupta, whose career spans journalism, politics and academia.

An alumnus of St Paul's School and La Martiniere Calcutta, Dasgupta urged the students to make the most of their school days. The state Finance Minister also spoke about the enduring value of

friendships forged during school. Dasgupta, along with Chandan Roy Chowdhury, President of the Bengal Olympic Association, later felicitated Jahangir Mollah, a para swimmer from Bengal, who will represent India at the Asian Games 2026.

At a time when the world faces pressing environmental challenges such as climate change, global warming, rising sea levels and the rapid depletion of green



“More than the classroom, it's what happens outside the classroom that can actually shape the future”
— Swapan Dasgupta,
West Bengal
Finance Minister

cover, Vanamahotsav at National High School once again served as a reminder of the collective responsibility to protect the planet. Shriya Chakraborty, Principal of National High School, CBSE campus, said, "Sustainability is no longer an ideology but a necessity. I am happy that 23 schools have taken part in Vanamahotsav. It shows our shared concern for the environment."

The day-long event also featured inter-school environmental quiz competitions and environment-themed poster competitions.



Trending COURSES

Blended MBA course for working professionals from IIM Nagpur

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Following the successful launch of the first cohort of its blended MBA programme, IIM Nagpur has opened applications for the second cohort of the course for working professionals, delivered in collaboration with Jaro Education. Designed for mid- and senior-level professionals, the two-year programme enables participants to strengthen managerial, strategic, and leadership capabilities while continuing their full-time careers.

The inaugural cohort witnessed participation from professionals across

industries, including information technology, healthcare, manufacturing, oil & gas, edtech, finance, consulting, aerospace, and banking, among others. The batch also reflected a diverse professional mix with participants ranging from two to 20 years of work experience and representation from multiple states, including Maharashtra, Karnataka, Delhi, Telangana, Bihar, Punjab, and Tamil Nadu. Professionals from engineering, management, commerce, healthcare, and technology backgrounds formed part of the cohort, highlighting the growing demand for flexible executive education across sectors.

BLACKBOARD

NIT Rourkela researchers have developed a smart wound dressing that prevents infections, minimises pain during removal, and promotes faster healing. In cases of injuries that require repeated dressing changes, patients usually suffer from the trauma and discomfort associated with them. The innovative wound dressing developed by Prof Prason Kumar, Department of Biotechnology and Medical Engineering, addresses this under-recognised challenge.

As Indian companies accelerate AI adoption and focus on technical upskilling, new research from International Workplace Group (IWG), the world's leading platform for work, suggests that the next workforce challenge is building the human capabilities needed to use AI creatively and collaboratively. According to IWG's survey, the vast majority (90%) of HR leaders believe that failing to prioritize human capabilities is a risk to innovation.

Calcutta Boys' School hosts 6th Assembly of Nations

Young diplomats reaffirm faith in global cooperation & need for UN reforms

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Calcutta Boys' School recently hosted the 6th edition of the inter-school Model United Nations Conference, Assembly of Nations (AON) 2026, reaffirming its commitment to nurturing responsible global citizens, future leaders, and skilled public speakers. Building upon the remarkable success of the previous edition, AON 2026 brought together students from leading schools across Kolkata on a common platform to deliberate upon contemporary international issues through the spirit of diplomacy, dialogue, and consensus-building.

The programme began with a processional prelude, followed by the opening hymn, and the lighting of the lamp. Raja McGee, Principal and Secretary, Calcutta Boys' School, highlighted the institution's vision of developing socially responsible and globally aware young leaders through academic excellence and experiential learning.



The chief guest for the inaugural ceremony, Dr Rahul Varma, Secretary General of the West Bengal Federation of United Nations Associations (WBFUNA), spoke about the enduring significance of the UN in addressing global challenges. Emphasising that the changing geopolitical landscape demands institutional reforms, he encouraged the delegates to embrace diplomacy, cooperation, and critical thinking in building a

more peaceful and equitable world.

The conference was also attended by Julia Martin-Legros, Attaché for Cooperation in French Language – East India, French Institute in India, Consulate General of France in Kolkata. She highlighted the importance of intercultural dialogue, multilingualism, and international collaboration in fostering mutual understanding among young people and praised the delegates for their

THE TWO-DAY EVENT
SAW DELEGATES FROM 14
SCHOOLS ACROSS KOLKATA
ACTIVELY PARTICIPATING
IN FIVE DIFFERENT
COMMITTEE SESSIONS

commitment to peaceful conflict resolution through diplomacy.

Over the course of two days, delegates from 14 schools across Kolkata actively participated in five different committee sessions, engaging in rigorous debates, policy drafting, negotiations, and consensus-building on pressing international issues. Representing countries from across the world, participants displayed impressive research abilities, analytical thinking, diplomatic temperament, and persuasive public speaking, reflecting the high standards of preparation associated with the conference.

IIT Gandhinagar to
develop India's first
indigenous cooling
tech for EVs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

An IIT Gandhinagar research team has won a seed grant to develop India's first indigenous cooling tech for EVs, AI infrastructure, railways and high-performance electronics. The researchers won a Rs 20 lakh seed grant at 'MATRIx 2026' (Materials Research, Innovation & Entrepreneurship Expo), organised by the Indian Institute of Metals (IIM), the professional body for metallurgists.

This technology can address two major issues - cooling of the fast-growing AI-driven data centres in India, where cooling is now a primary constraint and safety concerns around electric-vehicle battery thermal management.

This indigenous manufacturing technology could help address industrial thermal management through a new generation of liquid cold plates. Titled 'Advanced Chill Tech,' this innovation rethinks how liquid cold plates are manufactured, creating an avenue for an affordable, scalable and sustainable innovation.